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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

NEPAL IS ORIGIN OF VEDIC SANATAN CULTURE: PRESIDENT

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb 13:

President Ramchandra Paudel has said Nepal is the place of origin of the Vedic Sanatan culture.

Inaugurating the Shreemad Bhagawat Saptah Gyan Mahayagya, a religious programme, organised by the Gargi Kanya Gurukula, a school for girls, today, the Head-of-the-State believed that the State will pay special attention for the development of the Gurukula.

He highly appreciated the role played by the Gargi Kanya Gurukula Vidyashram school in providing the Vedic education to the girls.

"Women should be made educated, self-reliant and empowered in order to make the society civilized, well-cultured and prosperous," the President said.

As he said, it was a matter of happiness that the Gargi Kanya Gurukula has made arrangements for providing the Vedic education to girls in an environment reflecting the Gurukula tradition in the context of lack of provision for giving such education to girls in an appropriate manner at the existing Gurukulas in the country.

He stated that it is laudable work that saints and holy persons in Devghatdham have been operating ashramas and Gurukulas following the motto of ancient saints and hermits, highlighting the importance of the place.

"I have the inkling that the human resources educated in the Gurukulas can play a key role in the protection of the original culture, tradition, co-existence and self-esteem belonging to own soil," the President said.

Stating that the Vedas, the most ancient scriptures, are considered the source of spiritual knowledge and science, he viewed that Nepal is known as the 'land of the gods and of the quest for spiritualism'.

The President said sages and saints as Vasistha, Vishwamitra, Yagyawalkya, Ashtabakra and Gargi observed penance and meditated in various holy places of Nepal in the ancient period, gaining mystical power on the basis of their rigorous meditation.

Bagmati province government minister for tourism Pukar Maharjan said the provincial government will extend maximum possible support for the development of Gargi Gurukula Vidyasharam that is linked with Vedic Sanatana culture.

He, on the behalf the province government, pledged to provide Rs 4.5 million support for the development of Gargi Gurukula and Rs 500,000 to the Mahayagya programme.

Mayor of Bharatpur Metropolitan City, Renu Dahal, sad the Gargi Gurukula Vidyasharam will help in producing wise and able women citizens. She pledged the necessary support from the side of the Metropolis for the progress of the Gurukula.

Dr Govinda Tandon, the Coordinator of the Mahayagya Organizing Main Programme Committee, informed that the Gargi Kanya Gurukula Vidyashram was established in 2075 BS with the goal of raising spiritual awareness in women.

The Shreemad Bhagawat Mahayagya religious programme that was inaugurated today will run till February 21.

PALPA ROAD ACCIDENT: EIGHT DIE ON THE SPOT, 18 INJURED

RSS
Rampur (Palpa), Feb 13:

Eight people have died and 18 others were injured in a road accident that took place in the district today.

According to the District Police Office (DPO), Palpa, the accident involving a passenger jeep took place at Masyam of Tinau rural municipality-6 in the district.

The identity of the deceased has not been ascertained yet, while the injured have been sent to Lumbini Medical College in Palpa.

The jeep was carrying passengers to Kusumkhola in Palpa from Dumre in Tanahu district, police said.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN
Prime Minister and Chairman of CPN (Maoist Centre) Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' addressing the party's first statute convention in Kathmandu on Tuesday.

PM urges forces of People's War to unite

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 13

Prime Minister and CPN (Maoist Centre) Chairman Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has appealed to all those who contributed to making the 'People's War' a success to unite.

During the inauguration of the 29th People's War Day organised by the party in Kathmandu on Tuesday, he said that those who sacrificed for change should not face unwarranted accusations.

Characterising this moment as a prime opportunity for all revolutionaries to unite, PM Prachanda urged cadres to consolidate into one united front. He asked for prompt action in convening discussions and initiating a fresh wave of movement. Addressing fellow members of the Maoist movement, the PM insisted on forging unity within forces who fought for political change.

Highlighting the significance of advancing with a focus on social justice and prosperity, PM Prachanda called upon everyone to stand united on this day. Expressing confidence in the enduring importance of the 'people's war' in Nepal's history, he reflected on the past when they recognised the feasibility of such a movement in Nepal, receiving widespread support from the populace.

In extending his felicitations on the occasion of the 'People's War' Day, the party's Senior Vice Chairman and

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STATUTE CONVENTION OF CPN (MC) BEGINS

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 13

Prime Minister and Chairman of the CPN (Maoist Centre) Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' inaugurated the first Statute Convention of the CPN (Maoist Centre) in Kathmandu on Tuesday.

Dev Prasad Gurung, General Secretary of the CPN (Maoist Centre), informed that discussions would be carried out on the proposed statute by forming 20 groups each consisting of 50 to 55 members.

He said that each group would hold discussions on the draft statute till 1:00 pm Wednesday and present their conclusion before the plenary to take place tomorrow.

The Statute will be finalised based on the suggestions received from all 20 groups.

More than 1,200 delegates including central members, alternate central members, three central commission members, officials of seven provinces and officials of sister organisations were present at the conference. The three-day conference will conclude on Thursday.

TAL project recognised for exemplary conservation

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 13

The Tarai Arc Landscape (TAL) has been recognised and honored as one of the seven UN World Restoration Flagships as part of the UN Decade on Ecosystem Restoration.

This exceptional conservation outcome has been possible under the leadership of the government, stewardship of the communities and engagement of civil society. This collaborative effort has helped protect and restore forests, increase species population, and enhance ecosystem services and transborder corridor functionality.

This has garnered international recognition, positioning the Terai Arc Landscape as a pioneer in implementing landscape-level conservation practices worldwide, experts said.

The transboundary Tarai Arc Landscape serves not only as a biodiversity hotspot but also as a true testament to the effectiveness of the landscape approach of conservation, said Dr. Birendra Prasad Mahato, Minister for Forests and Environment, at a function organised to inform about the achievement on Tuesday.

"We are incredibly grateful for this recognition from the UN and are encouraged to continue tackling existing and new challenges faced by our forests, wildlife, and communities," Minister Mahato said.

Extending over 900 km from the Bagmati River, Nepal, in the east to the Yamuna River, India, in the west, TAL covers an expansive area of 51,002 square kilometres.

The area extends from the Bagmati River in the east to the Mahakali River in the west covering six protected areas, four forest conservation areas, three Ramsar sites and several critical corridors and spreads in over 24,710.13 square kilometres.

TAL envisions a globally unique landscape where biodiversity is conserved, ecological integrity is safeguarded, and the socio-economic well-being of the people is secured. In line with the 50-year vision, TAL aims to conserve ecosystems of the Tarai and Churia hills while ensuring the safeguarding of the rights of indigenous people and the local community.

"The Tarai Arc Landscape initiative does not protect nature by pulling people out of it, but by bringing people and nature closer together," said Inger Andersen, Executive Director of UNEP. "After decades of uncontrolled exploitation and degradation, resources are now urgently needed to rebuild that connection and restore vital ecosystems. This is key to tackling climate change, biodiversity loss and rampant pollution," Andersen said.

"WWF's continued support is highly appreciated for this huge success," said Dipak Gyawali, Deputy Director General of the Department of Forests and Soil Conservation.

"Two decades of collective efforts have made this achievement possible," said Bed Kumar Dhakal, Officiating Director General of the Department of National Parks and Wildlife Conservation.

» SEE PAGE 6



Shree Panchami today, heralds arrival of spring

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb, 13

A special Basanta Shrawan programme will be organised in the morning at Nasalchowk of the Hanumandhoka Durbar Square.

The festival of Shree Panchami also called Basanta Panchami will be observed across the country on Tuesday by worshipping goddess Saraswati.

The festival also marks the arrival of the spring season.

On Shree Panchami, Hindu devotees pay homage to the goddess Saraswati, the goddess of knowledge, wisdom, music, culture and art. A special Basanta Shrawan programme will be organised in the morning at Nasalchowk of the Hanumandhoka Durbar Square.

Different schools and educational institutions will organise Saraswati Puja on their premises. Traditionally, children are taught to write their first words on Basanta Panchami.

Basanta Panchami is the most revered celebration for students. People visit the nearby Saraswati Temple to invoke wisdom and consciousness in human beings.

Notebooks, pencils, books, and pens are kept at the goddess's feet to receive blessing from the goddess of knowledge. The goddess is believed to shower her blessing also on art, culture and music enthusiasts.

Similarly, Shree Panchami is celebrated by worshipping the goddess of wisdom Sadiathatri Devi in Rajbiraj, Saptari. They offer sweet potato and Buniya to goddess Saraswati as a prasad. Fruits, paan, nuts and laddu are also offered to the goddess by chanting mantras.

Nepal enters ACC Women's Premier Cup quarter-finals

BY NAYAK PAUDEL
Kathmandu, Feb. 13

Rubina Chhetry Belbase, former captain, proved her mettle once again after becoming the first Nepali women cricketer to score a century in T20I.

She has been one of the most dependable individuals in Nepal's women's cricket team since 2019.

Rubina's century came in Nepal's final group match in the ACC Women's Premier Cup in Malaysia on Tuesday while facing the Maldives. The century propelled Nepal to post a massive target of 228 runs in the loss of four wickets.

The first century for the team came in the country where Nepal had debuted in women's cricket. Nepal's women's team made its international debut in the Asian Cricket Council Women's Tournament in Malaysia in July 2007 playing against Thailand.

It was only after the ICC granted full Women's Twenty20 International status to all its members in July 2018 that Nepal played its first T20I against China at the 2019 Thailand Women's T20 Smash. Including Tuesday's match against the Maldives, Nepal has played 53 matches winning 37 since 2019.

Alongside the first century for the national team, Nepali cricket fans were overjoyed by the team's performance with the ball as the bowlers bundled the Maldives' team at only 13 runs to win the match by 214 runs in Bangi's YSD-UKM Cricket Oval.

Winning the toss and electing to bat first, openers Kabita Kunwar and Sita Rana Magar departed after scoring 13 and 15 runs respectively while captain Indu Barma was caught out for a golden duck. Dolly Bhatta (6 off 4) was the final wicket that fell for Nepal in the first inning.

It was Rubina, who came in at four, and Puja Mahato, who came in at six, took Nepal to 227 runs from 61/4 in 6.2 overs. It only took Rubina 59 balls to score 118 runs with 10 fours and 5 sixes. She was the player of the match.

Similarly, Rubina's 118 is the tournament's highest individual score in the edition.

Puja also played a quality inning as she scored her maiden half-century. She added 59 off 36 for the team.

Rubina's 118 runs is now the highest individual score in international cricket among Nepal's women cricketers. Earlier, Sita's 82 runs against Qatar in November 2021 was the highest individual score.



PHOTO: ACC VIA CAN
Rubina Chhetry Belbase reacts after scoring her maiden century against Maldives at the ACC Women's Premier Cup in Malaysia on Tuesday.

Only four Nepali women cricketers – Sita, Rubina, Indu and Puja –have scored a half-century in the T20I to date.

Shamma Ali bagged three wickets and Nabaa Binthu Naseem took one for the Maldives.

Chasing a massive target, Maldives' team, who lost by a large margin against Hong Kong and Bhutan, was under extreme pressure against Nepal. Earlier, Nepal defeated Hong Kong and Bhutan.

Kabita Kunwar started the bowling inning of Nepal with a maiden over and Puja took the first wicket by sending opener Leen Luthufee back to the dugout without being able to open her account (0 off 10).

Nepali bowlers did not allow any batter of the Maldives to score in double figures; besides, five others – Fathimath Malha, Maaha Naseer, Fathimath Anaal, Aishath Meesa Rameez and Shamma Ali – returned for a duck as Leen did.

Sumayya Abdul, captain of the Maldives women's cricket team, was the highest scorer for the team with 5 runs in six deliveries. Sumayya was the only Maldivian batter to hit a boundary against Nepal.

Kabita did not take any wickets, but she gave only two runs, both as wide, in her three-over spell. Meanwhile, Ashmina Karmacharya bagged a four-wicket haul and Puja and Rubina claimed three each.

Puja also bowled a maiden over in her three-over spell and gave only two runs. Ashmina (4 overs) and Rubina (3.5 overs) bowled two maiden overs each and gave only 7 and 2 runs respectively.

Meanwhile, it was not the first time for the Maldives women's side to face such a loss against Nepal. In December 2019, the Maldives was bundled out at 8 runs by Nepal at the South Asian Games Women's Cricket Competition. The Maldives was also bowled out at only 6 runs by Bangladesh in the same competition.

All 16 teams in the tournament divided into four groups have played three respective group matches each by Tuesday and the top two teams from each group will play in the playoffs.

Winning its three group matches, Nepal tops Group D with 6 points followed by Hong Kong (4 points).

As per the format of the tournament, the top teams from Group A and Group D will face the second-positioned teams in the opposite groups in the quarter-finals. Thus, Nepal is facing Kuwait, the second-positioned team of Group A, on Wednesday.

In three other quarter-final matches, Hong Kong and Thailand, Indonesia and the UAE, and Malaysia and Japan are competing.

Nepal will be eying a win against Kuwait to advance to the semis as the team is determined to return home with the trophy.

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NEPSE	: 2,070.59
Total Amount	: 4,667,179,304.14
No. of Share	: 12,165,202

'PPP MUST FOR DEVELOPMENT'

RSS
Morang, Feb 13

Chief Minister of Koshi Province, Kedar Karki, has said public-private partnership is essential for economic prosperity. For such collaboration, government is committed to support industrialists and entrepreneurs, he vowed.

In the sixth Province Assembly meeting of FNCCI here Monday, CM Karki reminded that government and businesspersons are complementary, so only option we have is effective cooperation and collaboration. According to him, businesspersons should create jobs and help in revenue generation, while government would facilitate promotion of entrepreneurship and industries.

On the occasion, Minister for Industry, Agriculture and Cooperatives in province, Ram Kumar Khatri, seconded CM Karki that government would take together private sectors for province prosperity. FNCCI Koshi Province chair Rajendra Raut underlined the need of private sector's participation in province investment authority.

PM assures justice to cooperative victims



PHOTO: PMO

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda recieving suggestions about coperative victims from Rastriya Swatantra Party President Rabi Lamichhane.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 13

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that he is actively working to give justice to millions of Nepalis who have been victimised by cooperatives and microfinance.

The Prime Minister made this remark while receiving suggestions providing justice to people suffering from cooperatives from the Rastriya Swatantra Party at Baluwatar on Tuesday morning.

A delegation of Rastriya Swatantra Party led by its chairman Rabi Lamichhane and vice-chairman Dr. Swarnim Wagle handed over the suggestion to the Prime Minister, according to a statement issued by the Prime Minister's Office on Tuesday.

The Prime Minister said, "I am most serious about this matter. Millions of those who had deposited money in cooperatives and microfinance have been defrauded. I am adamant that justice should be delivered to them at all costs."

Prime Minister Prachanda said that he would look into the suggestions made by the Rastriya Swatantra Party. "I want to solve this problem as soon as possible, I need your help in this regard," said PM Prachanda.

NRB encourages credit expansion in agriculture, medium enterprises

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 13

Nepal Rastra Bank has encouraged credit expansion in agriculture, small, domestic and medium industries. The central bank on Monday reviewed the monetary policy of the first six months of the current fiscal year and increased the credit limit for these sectors.

According to the NRB, arrangements will be made to allow the credit of up to Rs. 20 million in the agricultural, small, domestic and medium enterprise businesses to be counted in the regulatory retail portfolio.

Earlier, the limit of the regulatory retail portfolio was Rs. 10 million for agriculture, small, domestic and medium industries. Banks will be attracted to expand loans in these areas as the risk weight of loans calculated in the retail portfolio is only 75 per cent.

Through the semi-annual review of the monetary policy, the NRB has made new arrangements for the implementation of the interest rate of fixed deposits and the interest rate 'corridor'. To make the interest rate corridor effective, the permanent nature deposit facility will be implemented in February, said the NRB.

"When determining the interest rate of institutional fixed deposits, it will be arranged that it can be fixed by one percentage point lower than the interest rate provided for individual fixed deposits," said the NRB.

Given the internal and external situation and scenario of the economy and the policy arrangements made during the first quarter review, the rates under the interest rate corridor have been kept unchanged. The mandatory cash reserve ratio and statutory liquidity ratio have also been kept unchanged.

Casino Mahjong awarded in Mumabi

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 13

Casino Mahjong at Solti Hotel Complex received the prestigious "Outstanding Contributor to Tourism Development in Nepal" award at the 7th Hospitality India Travel event held in Mumbai, India.

The honour was presented during a ceremony attended by esteemed dignitaries including Shri Ramdas Athawale, Minister of State for Social Justice and Rights of India, and Anind Ganpat Sawant, Member of Indian Lok Sabha from the Shiv Sena Party, among others.

The event also saw the launch of the Hospitality India Coffee Table Book, connecting the global hospitality sector, by Mahjong Entertainment Pvt. Ltd.

Additionally, an interview featuring Binod Shrestha, Executive Director of Casino Major, highlighted his significant contributions to the tourism industry spanning over two decades, including accolades such as the Hospitality Award in New Delhi in 2023 and 2022, as well as recognition for Best Casinos in South Asia (2019) and Best Casinos in Nepal (2015).

Nepal Telecom's profit decreases by 7.6% in second quarter

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 13

The net profit of state-owned telecom company - Nepal Telecom (NT) - has decreased in the first six months of the current fiscal year 2023/24. Net profit of NT has decreased by 7.60 per cent during the second quarter of the current fiscal year compared to the same period last fiscal year, according to a press statement of the NT.

The company has earned a net profit of Rs. 3.93 billion in the review period of the current fiscal year 2023/24 while it had earned a net profit of Rs. 4.25 billion in the second quarter of the fiscal year 2022/23.

Meanwhile, the operating income of the company has decreased by 4.59 per cent during the review period. The operating income of the NT stood at Rs. 17.24 billion during the second quarter of the current fiscal year while it was Rs. 18.07 billion during the same period a year ago.

The NT was able to collect revenue of Rs. 21.30 billion by providing service during the review period which is 3.58 per cent lower than the same period last year. Total income of the NT was Rs. 22.10 billion during the second quarter of the last fiscal year 2022/23.

According to NT, the profit of the Company has been under pressure due to a decrease in the use of telecommunication services caused by the economic recession. The income and net profit of the company have decreased due to the decrease in interconnection income caused by the rising use of OTT services and the relative decrease in the use of the company's services due to the economic recession.

The Company said that due to the adverse effects of the weather, the power supply and maintenance work could not be done on time, so the sites could not be operated on time. Due to increased usage of the OTT service, the interconnection income decreased by Rs. 529 million during the second quarter of the current fiscal year as compared to the same period last fiscal year.

Owing to changes in the bank interest rates, the income also decreased by Rs. 347 million during the review period. The cost of NT has been increasing due to investment in improving quality services in remote areas, said the NT.

70% progress made in Arun III hydel



PHOTO: DHYAN KULUNG/TRN

Workers working in 900-megawatt Arun III hydropower project tunnel. 900 MW project has 70 per cent physical progress till now.

BY DHYAN KULUNG
Sankhuwasabha, Feb. 13

About 70 per cent of physical progress has been made in the 900-megawatt Arun III hydropower project being built in Sankhuwasabha district of Koshi Province. Progress has been achieved in the dam construction area, and tunnel and powerhouse construction works.

A dam for the project is being constructed at Phaksinda Dobhan located in Makalu Rural Municipality-5. Arun Dhiman, Chief Executive Officer of Satluj Jal Vidyut Nigam, the promoter of the Arun III Hydropower Project, said that construction of 2,548,000 cubic meters of the 2,556,000 cubic metre dam has been completed. He said that the concreting work of the dam will begin soon after managing the soil. The 11-km tunnel from the dam site to the powerhouse has already been opened. According to Dhiman, heading, benching and concreting works on the tunnel have reached the final stage.

Likewise, the construction of a powerhouse in Chichila Rural Municipality 3, Pukhuwa Dobhan, is moving in full swing. Ramesh Chandra Suleriya, Deputy General Manager of Arun III Hydropower Project, said that the entire structure of the powerhouse would be underground.

Suleriya said that the required two halls (rooms) have already been constructed and concreting and equipment fixing works in the halls were underway. The electricity will be generated by installing two turbines inside the halls. If the project faces no obstacle, the entire construction work will be completed within the next two years, it is said.

Stating that the construction work has been affected by the repeated interruptions as the locals have not received compensation, General Manager Suleriya said that even during the construction of the transmission line, obstacles were created in some places.

He said that more obstructions were created in Sankhuwasabha district for the construction of the 400 kV transmission line. Similarly, there is also disruption in Tamkemaiyug Rural Municipality of Bhojpur district. However, the works are moving ahead smoothly in other districts.

It has been arranged in the Project Development Agreement (PDA) that locals will get shares in the Arun III Hydropower Project only after the project is completed. It is mentioned in the PDA that shares will be given to locals within one year of the commercial production.

According to the PDA, shares worth Rs. 1.6 billion will be given to locals. Out of the said share amount, 50 per cent (Rs. 800 million) will be distributed in the first instalment and after the end of the first production year, the remaining 50 per cent shares will be distributed.

It has been said in the PDA that priority will be given to the directly affected locals while distributing the shares. The estimated cost of the project is Rs. 104 billion. Nepal will get 21.9 per cent of electricity generated from the project free of cost, and around Rs. 348 billion will be received as economic benefits.

The directly affected families will receive up to 30 units of electricity per month after the generation of electricity begins. It is mentioned in the PDA that the project will be handed over to the government of Nepal 25 years after its completion.

Construction of Hetauda substation to complete in a month



PHOTO: NEA

NEA MD Kulman Ghising inspecting Hetauda substation.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 13

Construction of the substation in Hetauda Sub-Metropolitan City of Makwanpur-11, Thanabhayang has reached the final stage.

To strengthen the electricity transmission and distribution system within the country, the 400/220 kV, 220/132 kV and 132/11 kV substations are under construction within the Hetauda substation.

With the goal of completing the construction and charging within a month, works of final stage such as connection and testing of the substation equipment are going on, according to a press statement of the Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA).

In addition to the electricity supply in the national transmission system through the substation, electricity will also be supplied locally from the substation.

Managing Director of NEA Kul Man Ghising, who visited the construction site recently, said that the progress made in the substation was satisfactory.

Ghising discussed with the project management and construction professionals involved in the construction and instructed them to complete the rest of the work and bring the substation into operation within a month.

There are three power transformers of 315 MVA capacity in the 400/220 kV Hetauda substation under construction under the Hetauda-Dhalkebar-Inaruwa 400 kV substation expansion project with the investment of the government and the NEA.

Under the project, 400/220 kV substations in Dhalkebar and Inaruwa have been completed and brought into operation.

A contract was signed in December 2018 for the construction of substations in Hetauda and Inaruwa.

The 220/132 kV Hetauda substation has been constructed under the under construction Hetauda-Dhalkebar-Inaruwa 400 kV double circuit transmission line project for strengthening the electricity transmission system within the country and for power export to India.

Government of Nepal
Ministry of Physical Infrastructure and Transport
Department of Roads
Mechanical Training Center, Patandhoka
Notice of LOI (Date of LOI): 14 February, 2024

This is to inform to all concerned bidders who had submitted their bids, invited under tender notice IFB Number mentioned below published on 22 December 2023 (2080/09/06) in "The Rising Nepal", that the "Letter of Intent" has been issued in favor of following bidders being substantially responsive and lowest evaluated bid price.

Sr. No.	Contract Identification No. and Detail	Bidder's Name & Address	Bid Price (Including VAT and PS)
1	***MTC/337310113/NCB/080-81/01*** *Construction Of Equipment Parking Garage in Heavy Equipment Division, Nepalgunj*	M/s Tila River Construction Pra. Li., Jumla, Karnali	***NRs 61,74,600.4***
2	***MTC/337310113/NCB/080-81/02*** *Construction Of Equipment Parking Garage in Heavy Equipment Division, Pokhara*	M/s Delight Builders and Suppliers Pvt. Ltd , Dolakha	***NRs 84,31,304.59***

Darchula-Tinkar road construction project moving at slow pace



File Photo: Lokendra Joshi\TRN

Minister for Physical Infrastructure Development Prakash Jwala and Lawmaker Dilendra Prasad Badu during the monitoring of the Darchula-Tinker Road on December 21, 2023.

BY LOKENDRA JOSHI
Darchula, Feb. 13

Darchula-Tinkar road construction project, which is being undertaken by the Nepali Army, has failed to take the desired pace.

In the first six months of the current fiscal year, only 720 metres of new track of the road has been opened while only 480 metres of the road has been upgraded.

The Nepali Army is constructing the road in the area of Byas Rural Municipality-2 from Tusharapani to Tambaku through the Dumling area.

Although the army has set a target to open three kilometres of new track and upgrade two kilometres of the road in the current fiscal year, no satisfactory progress has been made.

Locals are not happy when the minimum target of road construction has not been met this fiscal year.

According to the Nepali Army, road construction is underway in Phatanggad, Paltedhar, Kothdhar, Phulchimdhar, Tallo Dumling, Katha Dumling, Aktungti and Tambaku of Byas Rural Municipality-2.

The government has allocated a budget of Rs. 141.9 million in the current fiscal year for the Darchula-Tinker road project, but only Rs. 30 million has been spent in the last six months, according to Nepali Army Spokesperson and Brigadier General Krishna Prasad Bhandari.

Bhandari, information officer of the Nepali Army, said that out of the total 79 km long Darchula-Tinkar road, 10.5 km of track was opened last year and 1.5 km of the road was upgraded.

A team including Physical Infrastructure Development Minister Prakash Jwala and Lawmaker Dilendra Prasad Badu, who reached Sunsera for on-site monitoring of Tinker Road on December 21, 2023, gave instructions to build the road at a fast pace with the promise of allocating sufficient budget for the project.

However, the number of soldiers, workers and budget have not been added to expedite the Tinker road construction works.

According to the army, they have set a goal to take the road construction up to Malgaun by the new Nepali Year (2081)

The government has not been able to mobilise sufficient budget, machines and manpower so the work has not progressed.

The compressor machine could not be delivered to Kaljukshetra, said the Nepal Army.

According to the army, the construction of three kilometres of new track and the upgrading of two kilometres of road will be met according to the annual target, although the physical progress is minimal in the first six months of the current fiscal.

Urlabari residents in Hong Kong donate ambulance for needy



Photo Caption: Hari Prasad Koirala\ TRN

(Right) Nar Bahadur Moktan, Urlabari Ward No. 9 chairman, hands the ambulance's bluebook and key to the driver.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Urlabari, Feb. 13

Youths of Urlabari Municipality in Morang district who have been living in Hong Kong collected money and donated it to their hometown to buy an ambulance. Urlabari Hong Kong Family donated Rs. 2,550,000 for the ambulance which will be operated by the Ward No. 9 office of Urlabari.

The service, which is free for impoverished families, has come into operation since January 28.

Yam Sembo, a resident of Ward No. 9 living in Hong Kong, donated Rs. 500,000 alone. Sembo and Sangehang Tumbahamphe had initiated the money collection campaign for the ambulance.

"Urlabari Municipality is preparing a directive regarding poor families. After it is implemented, a poor family ID card will be distributed. The ID holders will receive the ambulance service for free while other locals will get a 20 per cent discount," said Nar Bahadur Moktan, Ward No. 9 chairman.

The municipality will cover the cost of the ambulance's driver and fuel.

Detainees at quake-damaged police custody at risk

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Jajarkot, Feb. 13

The District Police Office, Jajarkot, has been forced to keep detainees in earthquake-damaged custody of the police office.

The detainees were facing problems after all eight police offices including the District Police Office were damaged by the earthquake that jolted Jajarkot on November 3, 2023.

All the buildings of the district police office are cracked and unfit to live in. The DPO has been running their day-to-day office work from the tents.

The Karnali Province government provided financial assistance to the reconstruction and maintenance of the Women and Children Service Centre and the District Police Office.

Deputy Superintendent of Police (DSP) Santosh Roka of the District Police Office said although respecting detainees' right to live safely is very important, the renovated buildings are unfit to live in and there are no appropriate places to keep the detainees.



Photo: TRN

Detainees are being kept in this earthquake-damaged building of the district police office in Jajarkot.

The details of the damage have been submitted to the Provincial and Federal governments, Police Headquarters and Provincial Police Office.

Detainees and police personnel on duty fear living in those buildings damaged by the earthquake.

Among the eight buildings, one building is concrete. The daily office work is being delivered from the tent built on the roof of the communication service section.

Since all three governments did not take any initiative to relocate the earthquake victims to safe places, they had to live in cracked buildings to keep themselves safe from the cold.

Advocate and President of Nepal Bar Association Jajarkot Bhim Bahadur Shahi said that the earthquake victims were in trouble as the government had not put them a priority.

Shahi said that the government should prioritise detainees, health, schools, the poor, Dalits, the elderly, and the physically challenged, and advance the work of temporary housing and reconstruction.

Except for the Area Police Office, Sima, and the Police Office at Rimna, all buildings of police units in seven rural municipalities have been damaged.

TRN CORRESPONDENT KHADKA HONOURED

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Birtamod, Feb. 13

TRN Birtamod correspondent Lilaraj Jhapali was felicitated with the Best Journalism Award on Tuesday.

He was awarded on the occasion of the 66th establishment day of Kankai Secondary School of Surunga, Jhapa.

He has been engaged in the journalism sector for one and a half decades.

Bhupal Rai, Chancellor of Nepal Academy, Rajendra Kumar Pokharel, Mayor of Kankai Municipality, Aasha Shiwakoti, Deputy Mayor and Hira Kumar Thapa, former Agricultural Minister of Koshi awarded him with a cash price of Rs. 5,001.

On the occasion, Ishwari Prasad Shiwakoti, former principal of the school, and others were honoured.

Iih begins his Lumbini-Singha Durbar march

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Bhairahawa, Feb. 13

Activist Iih has embarked on a journey from Mayadevi Temple in Lumbini to Singha Durbar. He started the journey on Monday to make the government aware of the problems faced by the urban poor, street vendors and people associated with the informal sector. Iih is accompanied by another activist.

Activist Iih said that they started the journey to convey the Buddha's message of compassion to the government. During the journey, the problems would be collected by holding discussions and interactions with the road vendors and people associated with the informal sector in both rural areas and urban centres, said Iih.

"We want to convey Buddha's message of compassion and sympathy to the Singha Durbar. The journey will continue for nine days," he said.

He reached Tilottama of Rupandehi from Mayadevi Temple on the first day. He said he would reach Singha Durbar on February 19 via Sunwal of West Nawalparasi, Dumkibas of Nawalpur, Daldale, Ramnagar of Chitwan, Kurintar, Gajuri and Naubise of Dhading. Campaigner Iih has put forward three main demands in this regard. He demanded that the government should issue directives to manage and bring programmes in favour of the urban poor, and request to amend the law for their long-term management. "The disease of displacing the urban poor has become nationwide, therefore, it is necessary to raise the voice for the welfare of the poor in the society," said activist Iih.

Himal Upreti, an archaeological officer of Lumbini Development Trust, saw off the two activists.

NEWS BRIEF

Fire destroys property worth Rs. 5 million

Urlabari: A fire that broke out in the house of Arjun Bista of Baghejhoda in Kanepokhari-2, Morang, at 8 pm on Monday burnt his house, clothes and food grains.

According to Sushil Budhathoki, ward chairman of Kanepokhari-2, the fire was brought under control after 45 minutes with the efforts of the fire department, police and locals of Kanepokhari and Belbari municipalities.

Ward Chair Budhathoki said that a loss of Rs. 5 million was estimated in the fire.

Jewellery shop owner held

Kaski: Police have seized 7. 781 kilograms of raw gold and six kgs of silver ornaments from an Indian national in Pokhara Metropolis-2, Kaski.

The arrested national has been identified as Surjeet Bhowmik, 40, of West Bengal, India, according to a news bulletin issued by the Police Headquarters on Tuesday.

Acting upon a tip-off, the police squad deployed from the District Police Office, seized the gold, silver and cash Rs. 6.2 million from his Jay Bhairav Jewellers, Mohoriya Tole, Pokhara, on Tuesday morning. Police said Bhowmik was unable to show the source of the imported jewellery.

Tractor kills elderly in Sarlahi

Sarlahi: A person was killed when a tractor hit him in Haripurwa of Sarlahi district on Tuesday.

The deceased has been identified as Mahesh Raya, 55, of Haripurwa Municipality-1. The tractor with registration number Ja 1 Ta 6313 hit Raya near the Electric Sub-station of Haripurwa Municipality-1. He died on the spot.

Raya was returning to his home after working in the farmland, said police. Police said the tractor driver had been absconding. The body was handed over to his family after performing postmortem at the Provincial Hospital, Malangawa.

(TRN)

Government of Nepal
Ministry of Health & Population
Department of Health Services
Management Division
Pachali, Teku, Kathmandu, Nepal

Notice of Intention to Award

Date of Notice: 14 February 2024

Pursuant to clause 27(2) and 47(3) of Public Procurement Act 2063, this is to notify all the bidders that the following substantially responsive lowest bidders have been selected to award the contract as per the Invitation for Bids published on The Rising Nepal DOHS intends to award the contract to the same.

S. N.	IFB/ RFB No.	Item	Name of Successful Bidder	Total Amount CIP NPR
1	DOHS/G/ICB-16/ IDA/2080-81	Procurement of Portable USG Machine	**M/S Max Meditech System Pvt. Ltd.** New Baneshwor, Kathmandu	29,96,00,000.00

Nepal Airlines

NEPAL AIRLINES CORPORATION
CONTINUING AIRWORTHINESS MANAGEMENT DEPARTMENT
Tribhuvan International Airport, Kathmandu, Nepal

Notice of Invitation for Sealed Tender for NAC's A330-200 Base Maintenance Support Service

(International Competitive Bidding)
Date of First Publication 13th February 2024

Nepal Airlines Corporation (NAC), Continuing Airworthiness Management Department Invites Sealed Tender from Maintenance and Repair/Overhaul Organization (MRO) for base maintenance support services of its A330-200 aircraft fitted with RR Trent 772B engines. Sealed Tender must reach at the Office of the Continuing Airworthiness Management Department, Nepal Airlines Corporation, Tribhuvan International Airport, Kathmandu, Nepal in the office hours within Forty-Five (45) days from the date of first publication of this notice. The Maintenance and Repair/Overhaul Organizations (MROs) are encouraged to visit the Notice/Announcement page in NAC website: www.nepalairlines.com.np for detail information and downloading the Sealed Tender Document.

For further information, please contact:
Nepal Airlines Corporation
Continuing Airworthiness Management Department
Tribhuvan International Airport, Kathmandu, Nepal
Tel: +977 1 4113085 / 4113209, Fax: +977 1 4470768
Email: dir.camd@nac.com.np, dydir.epd@nac.com.np
Website : https://www.nepalairlines.com.np/notices

Upper Arun Hydroelectric Limited (UAHEL)
(A subsidiary Company of NEA)
Maharajgunj, Kathmandu, Nepal

Contract Award Notice

Client : Upper Arun Hydroelectric Limited (UAHEL) (A subsidiary Company of NEA)
Contract title : Tender Design, Preparation of Bidding Document, Construction Supervision and Post Construction Services for the Upper Arun Hydroelectric Project
Country : Nepal
RFP No. : **NP-UAHEL-336951-CS-QCBS** [formally known as PSRSHDP/UAHEL/S/QCBS-1]
Project No. : P178722

1. The successful Consultant

Name :	TRACTEBEL ENGINEERING GmbH, Germany (Lead firm) in Joint Venture with TRACTEBEL ENGINEERING S.A., France and WAPCOS LIMITED, India.
Address :	*Friedberger Strasse 173, 61118 Bad Vilbel, Germany*
Contract price :	EUR 23,384,807.60 and NPR 643,047,800.50 including VAT and Provisional Sum is USD 445,000.00

2. Short listed Consultants

Name of Consultant	Submitted Proposal	Weightage technical scores	Weightage Financial Score	Combined score and ranking
AECOM CONSULTANTS INC., Canada (Lead firm) in Joint Venture with LOMBARDI SA INGEGNERI CONSULENTI, Switzerland	Yes	73.35	10.06	**Combined Score: 83.41 Ranking: 2**
INGENIEROS CONSULTORES CIVILES Y ELECTRICOS SAS, Colombia (Lead firm) in Joint Venture with ARQ DAMS (PTY) LTD, South Africa and *ENERGY INFRATECH PRIVATE LIMITED, India*	No			
SMEC INTERNATIONAL PTY. LIMITED, Australia (Lead firm) in Joint Venture with AFRY SWITZERLAND LTD, Switzerland and DOLSAR ENGINEERING INC. CO., Turkey	No			
STANTEC INTERNATIONAL CONSULTING INC., USA (Lead firm) in Joint Venture with STANTEC CONSULTING SERVICES, INC., USA.	Yes	73.12	9.83	**Combined Score: 82.95 Ranking: 3**
STUDIO ING. G. PIETRANGELI- SOCIETA A RESPONSABILITA LIMITATA, Italy (Lead firm) in Joint Venture with TATA CONSULTING ENGINEERS LIMITED, India and ELECTRICITE DE FRANCE, France	No			
SU-YAPI ENGINEERING AND CONSULTING INC., Turkey (Lead firm) in Joint Venture with NATIONAL ENGINEERING SERVICES (PAKISTAN) LIMITED, Pakistan and CHINA WATER RESOURCES BEIFANG INVESTIGATION, DESIGN AND RESEARCH CO., LTD., China	Yes		Not Opened	Failed to meet minimum technical score of 800
TRACTEBEL ENGINEERING GmbH, Germany (Lead firm) in Joint Venture with TRACTEBEL ENGINEERING S.A., France and WAPCOS LIMITED, India.	Yes	*79.30*	15	**Combined Score: 94.30 Ranking:1**

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

No man has a good enough memory to be a successful liar.
- Abraham Lincoln

EDITORIAL

Maternal Healthcare

Pregnancy and childbirth should be moments of joy, but for many women in rural Nepal, the journey is fraught with risk and uncertainty. This is due to the lack of proper medical care. Improving healthcare access is crucial to ensuring safer and happier pregnancies and births. Many women in these areas never receive the necessary healthcare during pregnancy. The absence of proper medical attention often forces them into life-threatening situations. Pregnant women and new mothers in remote areas struggle to reach basic medical care facilities due to tough terrain and few healthcare options. Even with birthing centres around, many can't get there because of long distances. Also, these centres often lack medical staff and proper facilities.

The President Women Uplift Programme offers a glimmer of hope amidst the challenges. Since its inception in 2018, the government has provided free air rescue services to 630 pregnant and postpartum women who couldn't safely deliver or receive proper medical care in critical condition after childbirth. This initiative airlifts pregnant and postpartum women with complications to city hospitals, ensuring access to vital medical care. However, while these emergency interventions are essential, they do not offer a sustainable solution to the underlying healthcare disparities faced by rural communities. Article 38 of the Constitution of Nepal guarantees every woman the right to safe motherhood and reproductive health. Unfortunately, implementation gaps persist, particularly in rural areas.

The Safe Motherhood and Reproductive Rights Act of 2018 was enacted with noble intentions, yet inadequate infrastructure and substandard services in local facilities contribute to preventable deaths among pregnant women and new mothers. Maternal complications in Nepal, ranging from preventable issues like haemorrhage to non-obstetric challenges like self-harm, highlight the pressing need for better maternal healthcare. Strengthening referral systems, improving emergency transportation, and implementing early screening for danger signs are critical measures. These interventions can significantly enhance the quality of maternal health services and ultimately save lives.

Comprehensive and sustainable solutions are imperative to address the healthcare needs of rural mothers. Substantial investments are necessary to establish and upgrade healthcare facilities, train healthcare personnel, and improve road infrastructure for enhanced medical access. Equitable access to quality care, regardless of location, is essential for every woman. Policymakers must prioritise rural areas to fulfil the promise of safe motherhood and reproductive rights. Bridging this gap requires concerted efforts to ensure that no woman is left behind when it comes to accessing essential healthcare services. Inclusive and long-term strategies are needed, including investments in health care facilities and personnel, to tackle the root causes of inadequate maternal healthcare access.

For the early intervention of critical conditions in pregnant women, early screening is very crucial. Thus, sustained efforts are required to ensure regular check-ups and support throughout pregnancy and childbirth. In the pursuit of fair healthcare, policymakers must focus on implementing holistic interventions that address the multifaceted challenges faced by rural mothers. This includes establishing a community health programme, providing education on maternal health, and expanding telemedicine services to remote areas. Furthermore, partnerships with local organisations and community leaders can facilitate sensitive healthcare delivery.

Celebration Of Love

DIXYA POUDEL

There are rarely other festivals that divide people as Valentine's Day. It is a day for lovers while the singles are relegated to the periphery. In fact, most singles dread this day as lovebirds rejoice in each other's company. Roses are gifted, chocolates are savoured, candy hearts are shared and paper and plastic hearts are decorated in shops, as the general ambience is that of romance. As is seen, love is in the air once Valentine's Day nears. The social media is flooded with romantic themes, songs are sung about love, and even movies are released that cater to rom-com fans.

Globally, Valentine's Day is synonymous with love and romance. It isn't thus surprising that this highly saturated ambience can be quite a dread to the singles. Romantic love has been largely idealised in popular culture that leads people to believe in one true love or the notion of a soul mate. It is widely believed that there exists one perfect person i.e. a soul mate for everyone. Movies, books and music perpetuate this ideology. But what if the term love didn't exist? Would people fall in love then? According to the classical author, Francois La Rochefoucauld, "There are some people who would never have fallen in love if they had not heard there was such a thing."

However, it can be argued that language is just one way of stating the concept of 'falling in love.' People would still fall in love as it is inherent to human nature, even if they wouldn't give it the name 'love'. Love, amor, prem and maya are words in different languages that carry the significant notion of affection towards another person. As such, romantic love is just an aspect of love. There are also familial love and platonic love. But interestingly, romance is idealised above all else. Gazing into each other's eyes over a cosy date, lovers share a secret language that only they can understand. The surroundings tend to vanish as they exist only for one another.

And yet, often times, heartbreaks are inevitable either due to incompatibility or simply because they are wrong for each other. In the heat of attraction, red flags are ignored. Relationships, particularly romantic ones are difficult to navigate. One's hormones tend to be heightened in the initial stage of a relationship but they tend to falter as time passes. While falling in love is easy, sustaining it is more difficult.

In an age of internet, there are online dating sites which lure people with the promise of a perfect partner. However, it is important for people to be the kind of person they would desire in their partner. Self-love is paramount here, and so is self-improvement. While perfection may not be achievable, the effort on self-growth certainly shows which is quite attractive.

Saint Valentine is revered in Christian religion as a saviour of love who married couples in secret as the law banned marriages in the third century. Today, he is remembered and eulogised in the day of love i.e. Valentine's Day. However, each day can be a day to express one's love towards families, spouse, children and friends. Lucky are those who find enduring romantic love but it is vital to know that love can present itself in many different forms.

Promote Human Rights And Inclusion



Namrata Sharma

INSIGHT

As the World Social Forum (WSF) is taking place in Nepal on February 15-19, 2024, several deliberations will enquire into the civil liberties globally especially in South Asia. It will not be an exaggeration to say that the state authorities in most of the eight South Asian countries have undermined people's democratic rights and used repressive measures to silence the people in their countries. Situation in Nepal, Sri Lanka and Bhutan seem relatively better. However, there have been steps taken to curb civil liberties of the people in these countries too.

The last 75 years in Nepal have been a revolutionary tryst of a struggle between the authoritarian leaders and the people to institutionalise democracy. A struggle where the country has finally emerged from absolute monarchy to a federal republic, but the the lawmakers and general public still seem to be dominated by the patriarchal feudal mindset. The country has seen the fall and rise of dynasties, rewriting of the country's constitution several times, making several progresses in promulgating laws favourable to the marginalised communities. Implementation of the laws has been a struggle. But there are some very positive outcomes. For instance, Nepal is one of the few countries where the visitors have an option to tick a box containing "other" apart from "male" and "female" when they fill visa forms. The same option is there for citizenship, voter IDs, etc.

Gender parity

There are also gender parity indicators showing that Nepal is climbing up the ladder. However, while summing up the state of impunity in addressing gender justice and rights of people affected in conflict or other injustices, it can be said without hesitation that the dreams of the Nepali people is yet to be realised. The path of equality and prosperity is further fraught with challenges such as climate-induced events like earthquakes, floods and change in food cultivation. Trade and economic embargoes, imposed by India, also hampered our efforts to attain economic independence. The landlocked geography and geopolitical struggle of a small nation with two giant neighbours and western power structure is an ongoing, subtle reality of the country.

The social fabric of society consists of an indiscriminately accepted culmination of Budhhist and Brahminic Hindu which is intermingled in various festivals associated with events based on legendary anecdotes. This is a remarkable synthesis that has been achieved between two related but divergent value systems. From the only Hindu country in the world, Nepal is now a secular country where the less than four per cent Muslim, Christians and other religious communities fall under minority but say they feel safest. This harmony and culmination can be attributed to the rich prehistoric legendary traditions of the Newar indigenous community of the now Kathmandu Valley which was initially called the Nepal Mandal.

Several kingdoms were united by Prithvi Narayan Shah to make one Nepal. Ancient Indian classics suggest that the central Himalayan hills

> It is important to explore the possibilities of all South Asian nations of working collectively by putting in place mechanisms to advocate and restore the civil liberties and democratic rights of our people in all countries.

were closely related culturally and politically to the Gangetic Plains at least 2,500 years ago. While in the Budhdhist accounts, Lumbini, the birthplace of Sidhdhartha Gautama Buddha has prominence. The Hindu kings from high-caste started ruling over a population, majority of which were neither Indo-Aryan nor Hindu. Extensive cultural, trade and political relation were also established between Nepal and the then strong Tibet towards the north, transforming the valley from a relatively remote backwater into a major commercial centre between South Asia and Central Asia. Nepal's contacts with China began in a continuous basis only since the late 18th century.

This historic background has made the two giant neighbours of Nepal a key deciding factor in various socio-economic and political developments in the country even today. In integrating the peace process, Nepal again made history by having a government where the Maoists were included. Another historical and revolutionary fact of the federal Nepal is that as per the Local Election Act, two ward members or each ward needs to be women and one of them Dalit woman. For a total of 6,743 wards across the country, there will be at least 13,486 women where at least 6,743 are Dalit women. The country got first President from the Madhesi community. It also boasts of getting woman President, woman Speaker of the House of Representatives, and a woman Chief Justice. Therefore, it can be said that the issue of social and gender inclusion has been taken up to the political forefront.

Justice

The relationship of Nepal with other South Asian countries has always been cordial. In today's turbulent South Asia, Nepal is often the meeting places for South Asian level dialogues. Therefore, there are several lessons to be learnt from this small country. However, inside Nepal there is a lot to be done to make sure the freedom of press and human rights of all citizens are ensured by ending the growing rates of corruption and state of impunity on getting justice over crimes against humanity conducted in the past and currently.

Preventing the rights to protest, assemble, freedom of association, silencing dissent, curbing the freedom of the media, subordinating the judiciary are the tools used by the states to curtail civil liberties of the people. There have been several instances where curbing of right to protest, arresting of journalists who have unveiled corruption have happened. Therefore, during the WSF, it is important to explore the possibilities of all South Asian nations of working collectively by putting in place mechanisms to advocate and restore the civil liberties and democratic rights of our people in all countries.

(Sharma is a senior journalist and women rights advocate. namrata1964@yahoo.com Twitter handle: @NamrataSharmaP)

Will Cupid's Aim Improve?



Todd G. Buchholz

Cupid may be hitting the mark in the shopping aisle, but he's not having much luck coaxing couples down the wedding aisle. Although Valentine's Day spending on significant others will reach a record high in the United States this year, fewer Americans are marrying and having sex, leading to fewer babies being born. But there is evidence to suggest that Cupid's aim will improve in coming years. If we want to survive as a species, we should be rooting for the pudgy cherub's success.

It's easy to point to all sorts of dreadful news about the prospects for young people globally. A survey by Japan's National Institute of Population and Social Security found that 17.3 per cent of men and 14.6 per cent of women aged between 18 and 34 have no intention of ever tying the knot, while many young women are swearing off sex altogether. In the US, Generation Z tells pollsters that they will never earn enough money to buy a home, while 59 per cent of young people around the world say they are very or extremely worried about the planet overheating.

Acrostic romance

And yet a careful inventory of modern-day American dating and marriage trends gives hope that candlelight dinners for two are not a thing of the past. Let's organise our inventory with the acrostic romance:

Rings are pricey, with the average engagement ring costing about $5,500. But this average is biased upward by Kardashian wannabees, who stroll around with diamonds that could rival I.M. Pei's pyramid at the Louvre. One fascinating study revealed that couples who spend more on an engagement ring are more likely to get divorced. Thankfully, the median cost of an engagement ring has been going down, perhaps because lab-grown diamonds offer the same sparkle as their mined counterparts at a fraction of the cost. Moreover, many couples eschew new rings, preferring family heirlooms like great-grandma's Art Deco bling from the Flapper era.

Online dating is fraught with sharks and frauds. And yet it opens the door to a world of opportunities for the more than half of Gen Zers and Millennials who use these apps daily. In the "old days" in the "old country," wherever that was, villagers relied on matchmakers and arranged marriages (some still do). Even in the 1950s, the chance to marry someone from outside your county often depended on a college sojourn or an overseas vacation – options available only to the privileged. Today, finding a mate online costs relatively little, and a careful "shopper" can curate by looks, education, and hobbies, rather than relying on introductions from Aunt Sylvia's bridge partner.

Marriages are less common than in prior eras, and the age of a first-time married couple is climbing fast. While Steve Carell's titular character in the 2005 comedy The 40-Year-Old Virgin was an outlier to be laughed at, his

> Marriages are less common than in prior eras, and the age of a first-time married couple is climbing fast.

plight seems more plausible today. In 2021, 25 per cent of 40-year-olds had never been married, compared to just 7 per cent in 1960. But delaying marriage could make sense with rising life expectancy. In 1960, the average 40-year-old American male could expect to live to 73, whereas a 40-year-old today will likely reach 85. That still leaves many years of matrimonial bliss or bickering for those who postpone it.

Accommodations are pricey, with Zillow reporting that it takes nearly 12 years for a typical first-time US homebuyer to save for a down payment. So where can a youngish couple live? The COVID-19 work-from-home craze spurred city-dwellers to buy up suburban abodes and landlords to raise rents. Soaring inflation pushed up mortgage rates. But there are grounds for hope this year: ribbon-cutting ceremonies for multifamily buildings representing more than 700,000 new apartments are scheduled. Moreover, several states have recently passed laws permitting homeowners to construct backyard cottages.

Inventive ceremonies

Nullifications and divorces are down, which suggests that couples who do marry like each other more. In fact, the divorce rate has been plunging since 1980, and recently reached a 50-year low. Of course, that's no guarantee of happiness. The great comedian Jack Benny said that in 50 years of marriage, he and his wife, Mary, never considered divorce. "Murder, yes, but divorce, never." Ceremonies can be more inventive. American newlyweds spend about $30,000 on feeding and entertaining their wedding guests. No wonder 73 per cent of young couples think it's too expensive to marry! (Their parents might agree.) While few will choose an old-fashioned party in the church gymnasium under banners proclaiming, "Go Hoosiers," many are seeking more frugal celebrations on family patios and in back gardens.

Eros is the Greek name for Cupid, and he's puzzled by the discipline of young people. Compared to their parent's generation, they drink less alcohol, go to bed earlier, and more frequently go to bed alone. The share of 18 to 35-year-olds who did not have sex in the past year has doubled since 1990. Does this trend come from a rise in religion, a fear of rashes, or just a desire to stay at home playing video games? Regardless, when these unsexed singles finally meet the right mate, more than fireworks could explode.Nearly a hundred years ago, Cole Porter wrote the song "Let's Do It (Let's Fall in Love)," observing that, "Birds do it, bees do it, even educated fleas do it." Young people may be slow learners, but they're likely to catch on.

(The author is a former White House director of economic policy under President George W. Bush.)

- Project Syndicate

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

February 14, 1974

Policeman Held On Theft

Tulsipur, Feb 13: A policeman is arrested on the charge of theft in Salyan district, reports RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

TRN welcomes articles, letters and comments from our valued readers and contributors.
Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Strict Laws Control Corruption



I am writing in reference to the corruption and land scams that recently made headlines in Nepal. As such, corruption cases are common in Nepal which is a developing nation. Even though it has a relatively stable government currently, there are still stances of corrupt politicians who accept bribes for services.

This tendency to get involved in corruption has hampered the efforts to ensure good governance and tainted even the nation's image. Thus, there has to be ways to tackle such corruption from its root. It could mean stricter laws which are implemented without impunity to the guilty person, whatever his or her position or clout.

Strict laws would deter people from being so reckless when it comes to monetary gains. The fact that Nepal is ranked highly when it comes to corruption cases puts the nation's image to question. The government additionally has to raise awareness when it comes to charging the guilty persons and implementing laws and regulations that prohibit corruption.

Rakesh Gautam Jhapa

TAILPIECE

A man died and arrived at the Pearly Gates. St. Peter greets him and says, "Welcome. Come walk with me and I'll show you where you'll be staying. "As they're walking along the path he notices clocks on the Golden Fence of Heaven. He asks St. Peter, "What are all those clocks for?"

St. Peter replies, "They're clocks for every person in the world. They click once for each time you lie. "By the time they reach where the man is staying, he asks out of curiosity, "I didn't see any politicians' clocks. Where are they kept?" St. Peter calmly replies, "People here use them as fans."-

+++++

"Look, Charlie," the coach said, "you know the principles of good sportsmanship. You know the Little League doesn't allow temper tantrums, shouting at the umpire, or abusive language." "Yes sir, I understand." "Good, Charlie. Now, would you explain that to your father?"

Indian farmers start protest again

AP
New Delhi, Feb. 13



PHOTO: AP

Farmers marching to New Delhi gather near the Punjab-Haryana border at Shambhu, India, Tuesday, Feb.13, 2024. Farmers are marching to the Indian capital asking for a guaranteed minimum support price for all farm produce.

Tens of thousands of Indian farmers are marching toward the capital to demand guaranteed crop prices, renewing a movement from two years ago that succeeded in getting the government to repeal contentious new agricultural laws.

On Tuesday, police used tear gas, detained a number of farmers and heavily barricaded border points to block the protesters from entering New Delhi.

Authorities are determined to control the new demonstrations to avoid a repeat of the 2021 protests, in which tens of thousands of farmers camped outside the capital for over a year, enduring a harsh winter and a devastating COVID-19 surge.

The farmers, who rode on tractors and trucks from neighbouring Haryana and Punjab states, say the government has failed to meet some of their key demands from the previous protests.

In 2021, Prime Minister Narendra Modi repealed a set of agricultural laws that had triggered the first round of protests from farmers, who said the legislation would hurt their incomes.

But farmer groups that are leading the current march say that since then, the government hasn't made progress on other important demands such as guaranteed crop prices, a doubling of farmers' income and loan waivers.

The demand for guaranteed minimum support prices is at the heart of their protests.

Currently, the government protects agricultural producers against any sharp fall in farm prices by setting a minimum purchase price for certain essential crops, a system that was introduced in the 1960s to help shore up food reserves and prevent shortages. But the farmers are demanding that this be extended to all farm produce, and not just essential crops.

In November 2021, Modi's announcement that his government would quash the controversial laws was widely seen as a win for the farmers and a rare retreat by the populist leader.

The government had defended the laws as necessary reforms to modernize Indian farming, but farmers feared the government's move to introduce market reforms in agriculture would leave them poorer.

The protests, which began in northern India, triggered nationwide demonstrations and drew international support.

Political commentators said the protest movement was the biggest challenge until that time for the Modi government, which then tried to paint the move as a decision that prioritized farmers.

The protests come at a crucial time for the governing party and Modi, who is widely expected to sweep upcoming national polls and secure a third successive term.

In 2021, Modi's decision to do away with the laws was seen as a move to appease farmers ahead of crucial state polls. Farmers form the most influential voting bloc in India and are often romanticized as the heart and soul of the nation.

Politicians have long considered it unwise to alienate them, and farmers are also particularly important to Modi's base. Northern Haryana and a few other states with substantial farmer populations are ruled by his party.

If the protests were to gain the same kind of momentum as last time, it could pose a real test for Modi and his government just a few months before the general election.

Russia puts Estonian PM Kallas on wanted list

AP
Moscow, Feb. 13



PHOTO: AP

Estonia's Prime Minister Kaja Kallas talks to journalists as he arrives for an EU summit in Brussels, Thursday, Feb. 1, 2024. European Union leaders meet in Brussels for a one day summit to discuss the revision of the Multiannual Financial Framework 2021-2027, including support for Ukraine.

Russia has put Estonian Prime Minister Kaja Kallas on a wanted list, an official register showed Tuesday, as tensions soar between Russia and the West over Ukraine.

Kallas' name appeared on the Interior Ministry's register of people wanted in connection with criminal charges. It didn't specify what charges Kallas was facing.

It is the first time the ministry has put a foreign leader on a wanted list.

Kallas has been a strong supporter of Ukraine, spearheading efforts to increase military assistance to Kyiv and tighten sanctions against Russia.

She also has angered Moscow by pushing for the removal of monuments to Soviet World War II soldiers. Russia has laws criminalizing the "rehabilitation of Nazis" that include clauses punishing the desecration of war memorials.

Estonian Secretary of State Taimar Peterkop was also put on the wanted list, according to the register.

The moves appear to reflect an attempt by Moscow to up the ante as it faces pressure from NATO allies as fighting in Ukraine nears the two-year mark, but means little in practical terms as Russia-West contacts have been frozen during the conflict.

There was no immediate reaction to the move from the Estonian authorities.

Northeast of US preparing for coastal storm

AP
Hartford, Conn., Feb. 13

Parts of the Northeast were preparing Monday for a coastal storm that was expected to pack high winds and dump a foot or more of snow in some areas, leading to school closures, warnings against road travel and the possible disruption of flights.

The nation's largest school system in New York City said it was switching to remote learning and closing its buildings Tuesday because of the impending storm.

Some of the highest snowfall totals were forecast for the northern suburbs of New York City and south-western Connecticut, where 12 to 15 inches (30 to 38 centimetres) were possible, according to the National Weather Service. Wind gusts could hit 60 mph (100 kph) off the Massachusetts coast and 40 mph (65 kph) in interior parts of southern New England.

"It will make for a messy commute tomorrow morning," Christina Speciale, a meteorologist for the weather service in Albany, New York, said Monday. "This is a fast-moving storm, so things should be cleared out by tomorrow afternoon."

Massachusetts Gov. Maura Healey told all non-essential Executive Branch employees to not report to work Tuesday. Boston schools were closing and a parking ban was in effect. Similar closures and bans were put in place in other cities and towns. Emergency officials had equipment in place to help keep roads clear.

Boston Mayor Michelle Wu said the city's homeless shelters would remain open. "With the arrival of our first major snowstorm this winter, city teams are prepared to clear our roadways and respond to any emergencies during the storm," Wu said.

Healey warned of downed power lines and coastal flooding, saying the heaviest snow would be from 9 a.m. to 2 p.m. "Let's be smart and not too glib about things," Healey told reporters. "We haven't seen big storms in some time but the teams are predicting that this is going to be a real storm."

Rhode Island Gov. Dan McKee signed an executive order shuttering state government offices on Tuesday and banning tractor-trailer travel on all interstates and state roads beginning at midnight. McKee said he issued the tractor-trailer ban in coordination with Massachusetts, Connecticut, and New York.

Transportation officials in Pennsylvania warned against unnecessary travel and said vehicle restrictions would go into effect early Tuesday on the Pennsylvania Turnpike and other major roads.

US Senate passes $95.3 billion aid package for Ukraine, Israel

AP
Washington, Feb. 13



PHOTO: AP

US Senate Minority Leader Mitch McConnell, R-Ky., arrives as the Senate, at the Capitol in Washington, Monday, Feb. 12, 2024.

The Senate early Tuesday passed a $95.3 billion aid package for Ukraine and Israel, pushing ahead after months of difficult negotiations and amid growing political divisions in the Republican Party over the role of the United States abroad.

The vote came after a small group of Republicans opposed to the $60 billion for Ukraine held the Senate floor through the night, using the final hours of debate to argue that the U.S. should focus on its own problems before sending more money overseas. But 22 Republicans voted with nearly all Democrats to pass the package 70-29, with supporters arguing that abandoning Ukraine could embolden Russian President Vladimir Putin and threaten national security across the globe.

"With this bill, the Senate declares that American leadership will not waiver, will not falter, will not fail," said Senate Majority Leader Chuck Schumer, who worked closely with Republican Leader Mitch McConnell on the legislation.

The bill's passage through the Senate was a welcome sign for Ukraine amid critical shortages on the battlefield.

Yet the package faces a deeply uncertain future in the House, where hardline Republicans aligned with former President Donald Trump — the front-runner for the GOP presidential nomination, and a critic of support for Ukraine — oppose the legislation.

Speaker Mike Johnson cast new doubt on the package in a statement Monday evening, making clear that it could be weeks or months before Congress sends the legislation to President Joe Biden's desk — if at all.

Still, the vote was a win for both Senate leaders. Schumer noted the strong bipartisan support and projected that if the House speaker brings it forward it would have the same strong support in that chamber. McConnell has made Ukraine his top priority in recent months, and was resolute in the face of considerable pushback from his own GOP conference.

Speaking directly to his detractors in a floor speech on Sunday, McConnell said that "the eyes of the world" were on the U.S. Senate. "Will we give those who wish us harm more reason to question our resolve, or will we recommit to exercising American strength?" McConnell asked.

Dollars provided by the legislation would purchase U.S.-made defense equipment, including munitions and air defense systems that authorities say are desperately needed as Russia batters the country. It also includes $8 billion for the government in Kyiv and other assistance.

In addition, the legislation would provide $14 billion for Israel's war with Hamas, $8 billion for Taiwan and partners in the Indo-Pacific to counter China, and $9.2 billion in humanitarian assistance for Gaza.

Two Democrats, Sens. Jeff Merkley of Oregon and Peter Welch of Vermont, as well as Sen. Bernie Sanders, an independent, voted against it. The progressive lawmakers have objected to sending offensive weaponry to Israel.

The bill's passage followed almost five months of torturous negotiations over an expansive bill that would have paired the foreign aid with an overhaul of border and asylum policies.

PRISM

Moose visits Colorado ski resort

Colorado: Skiers and snowboarders at a Colorado resort had an unusual caught-on-camera encounter with a moose.

A video recorded by a visitor to the Winter Park Resort shows the moose lazily strolling near a group of skiers and snowboarders waiting for a chair lift.

There were no reports of dangerous confrontations or injuries resulting from the moose's visit.

A second moose was caught on camera the same day walking down the centre line of a nearby road, Berthoud Pass.

Visitors to Jackson Hole Mountain Resort in Teton Village, Wyo., shared video earlier this month of a moose that chased a group of skiers down a run.

Dog fends off lion attack

California: Security cameras were recording in a California neighbourhood when a family's dog fended off an attack from a mountain lion.

Giant schnauzer Holly was let out into her family's La Verne yard just before 9 p.m., and security cameras recorded the moment a mountain lion pounced on the 3-year-old, 93-pound canine.

Holly struggled with the cougar for 48 seconds before neighbours who witnessed the attack were able to chase the predator away.

Cameras recorded the mountain lion returning to the scene of the attack about 20 minutes later.

Holly was treated for a gash to her neck and is recuperating at home.

(AP)

TODAY IN HISTORY

1349 – Several hundred Jews are burned to death by mobs while the remaining Jews are forcibly removed from Strasbourg.
1655 – The Mapuches launch coordinated attacks against the Spanish in Chile beginning the Mapuche uprising of 1655.
1778 – The United States flag is formally recognized by a foreign naval vessel for the first time, when French Admiral Toussaint-Guillaume Picquet de la Motte renders a nine gun salute to USS Ranger, commanded by John Paul Jones.
1779 – American Revolutionary War: The Battle of Kettle Creek is fought in Georgia.
1779 – James Cook is killed by Native Hawaiians near Kealakekua on the Island of Hawaii.
1852 – Great Ormond St Hospital for Sick Children, the first hospital in England to provide in-patient beds specifically for children, is founded in London.

Migrant boats make music at opera house

AFP
Milan, Feb. 13



String instruments made from migrant boats met with sustained applause as they debuted at Italy's prestigious La Scala opera house in tribute to those who perish attempting the Mediterranean crossing to Europe.

The multicoloured "violins of the sea" were made by prisoners out of rickety boats washed up on the small Italian island of Lampedusa, a first port for many seeking to cross from North Africa.

The debut of the "Orchestra of the Sea" with the instruments, formed especially for the occasion, visibly moved the audience.

Two of the violin makers -- inmates from the high security Opera prison near Milan -- watched Monday's performance of Bach and Vivaldi from the theatre's royal box, usually reserved for state dignitaries.

"To be invited to La Scala for something we created is magic" said 42-year-old Claudio, one of the prison's four apprentice luthiers who is serving a life sentence for two murders.

Cracked and diesel-soaked wood from the migrants' boats, destined for the scrapyard, was transformed into the violins, violas and cellos.

"We give voice to everything that is usually thrown away: the wood from boats that is shredded, the migrants who flee war and poverty and are treated like trash, and the prisoners who are not given a second chance," says Arnoldo Mosca Mondadori, who came up with the idea.

Mosca Mondadori, president of the House of the Spirits and the Arts foundation, hopes the string instruments can be played in other concert halls in Europe, "to touch people's souls in the face of poverty". The central Mediterranean is the deadliest migratory route in the world. Nearly 2,498 people died or disappeared along it last year, some 75 percent more than in 2022.

In a courtyard at the Opera prison, dilapidated boats are strewn across the grass among broken planks of wood.

A pink and white baby shoe, a baby bottle, nappies and a tiny green T-shirt are among items recovered from their holds.

Discarded clothing stiff with salt, rusting cans of sardines, and rudimentary life jackets evoke perilous journeys at the mercy of rough seas.

"You can smell the sea here," within the grey concrete walls of the courtyard, 49-year-old prisoner Andrea said.

"It is very strong and transports you very far. It is present even in the instruments, though less so," he says as he dismantles boats and searches for suitable wood to make the instruments.

Andrea, who is serving a life term for murder, sees the time he spends in the wood workshop as a form of "redemption".

"Time does not pass in prison. But there, we feel alive and useful," he said.

In the small dark room with barred windows, Nicolae, a 41-year-old Romanian behind bars since 2013, is busy sawing a piece of wood.

He takes measurements, before carefully carving a violin's soundboard.

MANY LAWS REMAIN UNFORMULATED: NA CHAIR

RSS
Chitwan, Feb 13

National Assembly (NA) Chair Ganesh Prasad Timilsina has said the parliament has not been able to enact necessary laws. Talking to media on Tuesday, the upper house Chair acknowledged that various laws remained to be formulated.

He admitted that during his term at the NA, no laws were enacted by the upper house. "The government failed to introduce dedicated bill for the NA to draft acts".

However, each bill that the NA received for its business were endorsed through a due process one time, he said, adding that in this term, he assessed his tenure as successful.



PHOTO: RSS

Locals playing the traditional Panchebaja instruments at Dhawalagiri Rural Municipality in Myagdi district.

Preparations underway to open Churiyamai tunnel road

BY RAM MANI DAHAL
Hetauda, Feb. 13

Preparations are underway to open the Churiyamai Tunnel, Nepal's first tunnel in Chure along the Kathmandu-Tarai road Hetauda, for public after its renovation.

Approximately 106 years old tunnel constructed in Chure hill was blocked after the collapse of the middle section. However, the maintenance work was advanced after the Bagmati Province government reached an agreement with the construction company on May 2, 2021. The tunnel was cleared in June last year.

After clearing the collapsed section, it is now set to open for the public after beautifying it. Hari Prasad Ojha, Spokesperson for the Transport Infrastructure Directorate of Bagmati Province, said that the directorate had completed the construction work of the historical tunnel to develop it as a tourist destination.

He said, "Public can easily travel through the tunnel. However, it is yet to be decided which model will be adopted for the operation of the tunnel as payments are pending to the construction company."

According to the directorate, the construction of the tunnel cost Rs. 36.5 million as deadlines were extended as the length of the tunnel increased.

Brigadier Colonel Dilli Jung Thapa had designed the tunnel. The then Prime Minister Chandra Shumsher Jung Bahadur Rana had granted the leadership of the tunnel construction to Thapa. Under his leadership, the tunnel was constructed in 1917 and completed within two years.

India's Modi arrives in UAE on his seventh trip

AP
Dubai, Feb. 13

Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi arrived Tuesday in the United Arab Emirates on his seventh trip to the nation, preparing to be feted by tens of thousands of his countrymen ahead of elections back home in the coming months.

Modi was met on landing in Abu Dhabi by Emirati President Sheikh Mohammed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, a man he repeatedly has called his brother while working to bolster ties between the Arabian Peninsula nation that is home to millions of Indians. The two leaders walked past an honor guard before sitting down for their meeting, which saw bilateral agreements signed between the nations.

Modi lauded "our closeness and how we have moved forward in every field."

He added: "Brother, it is also a matter of happiness that we are going to do (a) bilateral investment treaty. This is also going to have a long lasting impact."

The two sides also discussed energy issues. India remains a key buyer of Emirati oil and now is looking at the possibility of buying liquefied natural gas from the UAE as well, a statement from the Indian delegation said.

The UAE offered no immediate readout on the trip or what the two men discussed.

Tuesday night, tens of thousands of Indians are expected to crowd into Zayed Sports City Stadium to see Modi. Only Indian nationals were being permitted to attend the event in Abu Dhabi, organizers said.

Modi's arrival came as Indian police on Tuesday used tear gas and detained some farmers who clashed with them and tried to break barricades, blocking their way to New Delhi to demand guaranteed crop prices. In 2021, farmers camped for months in the Indian capital after Modi withdrew controversial agriculture laws that had triggered the earlier protests.

The protests could pose a significant challenge for Modi and his governing Bharatiya Janata Party ahead of the coming elections in India, the world's largest democracy. However, Modi is widely expected to win a third term.

Of the over 9 million people living in the UAE, India estimates more than 3.5 million are Indian expatriates, making them the largest national group of people in the country, outnumbering even Emirati citizens. While many are low-paid laborers, there are a growing number of white-collar professionals and multiple generations of Indian families.

Modi's visit highlights the nations' longstanding economic and historic ties, from spice selling and gold smuggling in the UAE's formative years to tens of billions of dollars' worth of annual bilateral trade today.

The countries signed a free trade deal in 2022 aimed at doubling their bilateral trade to $100 billion. The countries have agreed to allow India to settle some payments in rupees as opposed to dollars, lowering transaction costs.

KU to host higher education summit

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 13

Kathmandu University (KU) is set to host the inaugural North Regional International Vice-Chancellor's Meeting and India-Nepal Higher Education Summit, a first-of-its-kind event in Nepal.

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal ' Prachanda' who is also the Chancellor of the University will inaugurate the conference on Thursday.

Over three days, the summit will explore contemporary issues confronting the global higher education landscape, under the theme of 'Globalisation and Internationalisation of Higher Education'. Kathmandu University, in collaboration with the Association of Indian Universities, is expecting participation from vice-chancellors and academics representing 150 universities from Nepal, India, Bangladesh, Malaysia, Thailand, and other nations.

Prof. Dr. Bhola Thapa, Vice-Chancellor of Kathmandu University, underscored the objective of internationalising Nepal's higher education and fostering global university partnerships through the Vice-Chancellor's Conference.

Ekkumaya Pun, the spokesperson for the university, outlined the agenda for the conference, emphasizing the exploration of research collaborations, student exchange programs, joint degree initiatives, and academic partnerships to enhance international cooperation in higher education. The summit will also focus on shaping future directions, regulatory frameworks, and policy clarity in global higher education. Additionally, discussions will centre on student mobility and diverse international experiences, along with strategies for promoting student exchange programmes.

PM urges forces of People's War...

Deputy Prime Minister and Home Minister Narayankaji Shrestha acknowledged the government's decision to grant a holiday to celebrate the event. He emphasised that even if the government were to revoke this holiday, revolutionaries would still commemorate the day with great reverence, underscoring its significance.

"There's no questioning the pivotal and decisive role played by the 'People's War', led by Prachanda, in effecting historical change in Nepal," Shrestha said. He emphasized Prachanda's instrumental leadership in advancing the peace process, which has profoundly transformed Nepali society. Shrestha reiterated that the establishment of the republic was a direct outcome of Prachanda's visionary approach to the 'People's War'.

While acknowledging the achievements of transitioning to a federal democratic republic, DPM Shrestha asserted that the party's primary objective should be to fulfil the remaining obligations of the peace process and progress toward a socialist-oriented democratic republic.

Stressing the imperative of consolidating all revolutionary forces to lay a new foundation for socialism, he emphasized the urgency of completing outstanding national sovereignty tasks, safeguarding achievements, fostering prosperity through good governance and concluding the peace process.

TAL project recognised for...

"WWF NEPAL is grateful and thanks the various agencies of the Government of Nepal, local communities, conservation partners, donors, and supporters for having us a partner in this incredible journey towards combined restoration efforts. Congratulations to all the concerned stakeholders for this historic achievement," Dr. Ghana Shyam Gurung, Country Representative, WWF Nepal.

The first 10-year TAL Strategy and Implementation Plan (2004-2014) provided a touchstone to guide and address conservation management issues and to tackle priority threats to make TAL an ecologically functional landscape. The second Strategy and Action Plan (2015–2025) has continued to guide and build on the conservation successes in TAL to ensure the socio-ecological integrity of the TAL over the next decade and beyond.

The initiative which started with the launch of the Terai Arc Landscape Programme in 2001 has already brought back to life 66,800 hectares of forest, increased the population of rhinos from 409 in 2005 to 752 in 2021, and nearly tripled its tiger population from 121 in 2010 to 355 in 2022.

The restoration success helped Nepal claim the result-based payment of USD 45 million through REDD+. The programme has also benefitted the local community through nature-based tourism, homestays, green enterprises, and many other initiatives through the engagement of local community members, community forest users, buffer zone communities, community-based anti-poaching units, citizen scientists and forest watchers.

Meanwhile, a press statement issued by the United Nations office in Nepal, said that the initiative, which started with the Government of Nepal's launch of the Terai Arc Landscape Programme in 2001 – has already brought back to life a forest area 13 times the size of Kathmandu, and nearly tripled its tiger population to 355 from 121. In the entire Terai Arc landscape, shared by India and Nepal, the population more than doubled to 1,174.

The World Restoration Flagship awards are part of the UN Decade on Ecosystem Restoration – led by the UN Environment Programme (UNEP) and the Food and Agriculture Organization of the UN (FAO) - which aims to prevent, halt, and reverse the degradation of ecosystems on every continent and in every ocean. The awards track notable initiatives following global commitments to restore one billion hectares – an area larger than China. The award for the Terai Arc Landscape initiative was announced by UN Environment Programme Goodwill Ambassador, actress and environmentalist, Dia Mirza.

As a World Restoration Flagship, the Terai Arc Landscape is recognised as one of the best examples of large-scale and long-term ecosystem restoration in any country or region, embodying the 10 Restoration Principles of the UN Decade on Ecosystem Restoration.

The announcement of seven new World Restoration Flagships was made ahead of the 6th UN Environment Assembly (UNEA-6) slated for February 26 to March 1.

The Assembly convenes the world's Environment Ministers in Nairobi, Kenya, to address the triple planetary crisis of climate change, biodiversity and nature loss, and pollution and waste.

Iran is 'not entirely transparent' on its atomic program

AP
Dubai, Feb. 13

The head of the United Nations' nuclear watchdog warned Tuesday that Iran is "not entirely transparent" regarding its atomic program, particularly after an official who once led Tehran's program announced the Islamic Republic has all the pieces for a weapon "in our hands."

Speaking at the World Governments Summit in Dubai, just across the Persian Gulf, Rafael Mariano Grossi, the director-general of the International Atomic Energy Agency, alluded to remarks made this weekend by Ali Akbar Salehi. Grossi noted "an accumulation of complexities" in the wider Middle East amid Israel's war against Hamas in the Gaza Strip.

Iran, after the collapse of its 2015 nuclear deal with world powers, has pursued nuclear enrichment just below weapons-grade levels. Tehran has accumulated enough enriched uranium to build several weapons if it chooses. However, U.S. intelligence agencies and others assess that Iran has yet to begin a weapons program. Israel long has been believed to have its own nuclear weapons program.

Iran is "presenting a face which is not entirely transparent when it comes to its nuclear activities. Of course this increases dangers," Grossi said. "There's loose talk about nuclear weapons more and more, including in Iran recently. A very high official said, in fact, we have everything, it's disassembled. Well, please let me know what you have."

Iran, as a signatory to the Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons, has pledged to allow the IAEA to visit its atomic sites to ensure its program is peaceful. Tehran also agreed to additional oversight from the IAEA as part of the 2015 nuclear deal.

Grossi did not identify the Iranian official who made the comment. However, in an Iranian state television show late Sunday, Salehi said that the country had all it needed to build a weapon.

"We have all the (pieces) of nuclear science and technology. Let me give an example," Salehi said. "What does a car need? It needs a chassis, it needs an engine, it needs a steering wheel, it needs a gearbox. Have you made a gearbox? I say yes. An engine? But each one is for its own purpose."

Salehi made a similar comment Saturday. "We have it in our hands," he said then.

Since 2022, Iranian officials have spoken openly about something long denied by Tehran as it enriches uranium at its closest-ever levels to weapons-grade material: the Islamic Republic is ready to build an atomic weapon at will. That includes Kamal Kharrazi, an adviser to Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, who told Al Jazeera that Tehran has the ability to build nuclear weapons but does not intend to do so.

Salehi's comments represent an escalation. He served as the head of the civilian Atomic Energy Organization of Iran under then-President Hassan Rouhani, a relative moderate within Iran's theocracy who reached the 2015 deal with world powers.

The hardening of Iran's position comes as militias it arms in the region — Lebanon's Hezbollah and Yemen's Houthi rebels — have launched attacks targeting Israel. The Houthis continue to attack commercial shipping in the region, sparking repeated airstrikes from the U.S. and the United Kingdom.

Meanwhile Tuesday, Iran released footage of a ballistic missile being fired off the Shahid Mahdavi, a container ship transformed by Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard into a floating base. The footage showed a Fateh missile fired from a launcher disguised as a shipping container, potentially meaning Iran could hide the launcher on other vessels.

Israel and Hamas making progress in cease-fire talks

AP
Cairo, Feb. 13



Israel and Hamas are making progress toward a deal that aims to bring about a cease-fire and free hostages held in the Gaza Strip, according to two officials with direct knowledge of the talks, as key meetings continue Tuesday in the Egyptian capital.

Talks are moving forward even after Israel intensified its offensive in the southern Gaza town of Rafah, where 1.4 million displaced Palestinians have fled to seek shelter from fighting elsewhere. Israeli forces rescued two captives held in the town along the Egyptian border in a raid that killed at least 74 Palestinians, according to local health officials, and left a trail of destruction.

A deal would give people in Gaza a desperately needed respite from the war, now in its fifth month, and offer freedom for at least some of the 100 people still held captive in Gaza. With the war grinding on, efforts mediated by Qatar, the United States and Egypt to bring about a deal have been hobbled by the starkly disparate positions of Hamas and Israel.

Israel has made destroying Hamas' governing and military capabilities and freeing the hostages the main goals of its war, which was launched after thousands of Hamas-led militants rampaged through southern Israel, killing 1,200 people, mostly civilians, and taking roughly 250 people captive. Tens of thousands of Israelis were displaced from destroyed communities.

The war has wrought unimaginable destruction in the Gaza Strip, with more than 28,000 people killed, more than 70% of them women and minors, according to local health officials. Vast swaths of the territory have been flattened by Israel's offensive, around 80% of the population has been displaced and a humanitarian catastrophe has pushed more than a quarter of Palestinians in Gaza toward starvation.

South Africa, which has lodged genocide allegations against Israel at the International Court of Justice, said on Tuesday that it filed an "urgent request" with the court to consider whether Israel's military operations in Rafah constitute a breach of provisional orders handed down by the justices last month.

Israel has adamantly denied the allegations and insists it takes every measure to spare civilians.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has vowed to press on until "total victory," and has insisted that strong military pressure will secure the hostages' freedom — an idea his allies say was bolstered by the successful rescue mission. But the rescued hostages, Fernando Marman, 60, and Louis Har, 70, were just the second and third captives to be freed by the military since the war erupted.

Other Israeli officials have said only a deal can bring about the release of so many hostages.

A deal in late November brought about a brief truce in exchange for the release of about 100 hostages. About 240 Palestinians imprisoned by Israel were also freed as part of the deal.

Couples marking Valentine's Day today



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG

Two boys selling roses on the eve of Valentine's DAy at Kamaladi, Kathmandu, on Tuesday.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 13

Saint Valentine's Day is celebrated on February 14 every year all over the world. Valentine's Day has become popular among the youth in recent years even though it is not a common festival in Nepal.

People of the young generation, especially in the urban and city areas, celebrate it with much fanfare. Although Valentine's Day is not a part of Nepali culture, it has become a highly anticipated event not just for teenagers but also for the older generations.

Before Valentine's Day, there is a practice of marking the seven days of the week with different names - Rose Day, Propose Day, Chocolate Day, Teddy Day, Promise Day, Hug Day and Kiss Day. Shops, restaurants and clubs have managed special offers and discounts for couples willing to celebrate Valentine's Day.

Sales of roses have soared at several flower shops in the Kathmandu Valley and other cities of the nation after Valentine's Week began on Wednesday with Rose Day.

Targeting Valentine's Week, the Floricultural Association Nepal (FAN) has imported 315,000 stems of roses from India. The demand for and import of roses are higher ahead of Valentine's Day than at other times. It is assumed that roses worth Rs. 350 million are transacted during Valentine's Week, FAN said.

Valentine's Day this year coincided with the day of Shree Panchami.

Teachers' salaries managed through traditional dance

BY THAKUR PRASAD ACHARYA
Myagdi, Feb. 13



In a village of Myagdi, school teachers' salaries are covered by the earnings made from 'Purkhyauli Naach'(traditional dance) performances.

The residents of Malampar, a remote settlement in Dhaulagiri Rural Municipality-5, have taken the initiative to support their Shree Mahendra Basic School by performing the Purkhyauli dance at various events such as weddings, chhewar and other religious functions.

To facilitate this effort, a local Purkhyauli group has been formed, comprising artists who come to the village to perform at events like sacred thread ceremonies, chhewar and other religious ceremonies.

Over the past 22 years, the residents of Malampar have been diligently collecting funds to pay the teachers of the school.

Bhakta Bahadur Chhantyal, chairman of the school management committee and a member of the local ward, disclosed that the school, which provides education up to class 8, relies on the collected funds to pay the salaries and allowances of three teachers and cover other operational expenses.

There are a total of nine teachers and staff in the school.

Chhantyal lamented the necessity of having to manage the school through such means, revealing that while teachers up to class five hold government posts, funds for teachers beyond that level, up to class 8, are raised by performing the Purkhyauli dance.

He further added that an annual sum of Rs. 400,000 to Rs. 600,000 is collected through the dance performances, with families contributing varying amounts based on their financial capacity.

The recent performance of the Purkhyauli dance at the 'Purpuro' ceremony for the eldest son of local Khim Bahadur Chhantyal exemplifies this tradition.

With the community's resilience in maintaining their tradition and supporting education, 81 children continue to receive education at the school.

Blackpink K-pop star Lisa to join cast of 'White Lotus'

AGENCIES
New York, Feb. 13



Blackpink singer Lisa will make her acting debut in the third season of hit US television series The White Lotus, becoming the second member of the popular South Korean K-pop girl group to appear on HBO, Variety reported on Monday.

Lisa will be credited under her full name, Lalisa Manobal, and joins a previously announced cast including Parker Posey, Jason Isaacs, Leslie Bibb, Michelle Monaghan and returning star Natasha Rothwell, who was nominated for an Emmy for her role as hotel masseuse Belinda in season one. Manobal's role on the show, which focuses on intrigue at exotic resorts, was not disclosed.

Season three of The White Lotus will begin production in Koh Samui, Phuket and Bangkok, Thailand in February. While exact plot details are still under wraps, the show's creator, writer and director Mike White has previously teased that the third season could be "a satirical and funny look at death and eastern religion and spirituality".

All four members of Blackpink have renewed their contracts with South Korea's YG Entertainment Inc, the label said in December, sending shares of the company up by nearly a third.

Lisa's bandmate Jennie appeared in the HBO drama The Idol in 2023, credited under the moniker Jennie Ruby Jane.

Blackpink set a Guinness record earlier this year for having the most-viewed music channel on YouTube, which now boasts more than 90 million subscribers.

The White Lotus's first season was set in Hawaii, earning 20 Emmy nominations and 10 wins.

Season two, set in Sicily, was up for 23 Emmy nominations and won five, including one for best casting, and one for fan favourite Jennifer Coolidge.

Deepika Padukone to present honour at BAFTA Awards

AGENCIES
Mumbai, Feb. 13



Deepika Padukone has been confirmed as one of the presenters for the upcoming BAFTA (British Academy of Film and Television Arts) awards, alongside footballer David Beckham, actor Cate Blanchett, and singer Dua Lipa. Each of these global stars will present an award during the ceremony on February 19, though the specific categories have not yet been disclosed. Previous presenters announced include Hugh Grant, Lily Collins, Adjoa Andoh, Emma Corrin, Gillian Anderson, Himesh Patel, and Idris Elba.

The evening promises to be star-studded with notable performances, including a special cover song by Hannah Waddingham and a rendition of Sophie Bexter's 24-year-old track "Murder on The Dancefloor." The Rising Star Award will be presented by former winners Emma Mackey and Jack O'Connell.

Deepika Padukone, who previously presented an award at the 2023 Oscars, continues to represent Indian film stars on the global stage. This recognition underscores the increasing popularity of Indian cinema, particularly highlighted by SS Rajamouli's film RRR winning an Oscar in 2023 for its song "Naatu Naatu" in the Best Original Song category.

Among the films receiving attention at the BAFTA Film Awards are historical drama "Oppenheimer" with 13 nominations, gothic comedy "Poor Things," and Martin Scorsese's "Killers of the Flower Moon," each earning nine nominations. The ceremony is set to take place on February 19 at London's Royal Festive Hall.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: An argument with friends or on social media could escalate out of hand without warning. As potent Mars meets earth-shaking Pluto in your 11th House of Community, you may see standing up for yourself as necessary for your self-worth!.

Taurus: Getting locked into a dramatic showdown with a gratuitously cruel authority figure is a risk now. As the delicate Moon moves into your sign, you could be the perfect foil for this character -- you can really.

Gemini: Pushing your political or spiritual views on others could be appealing to you today. Perhaps this seems easier than addressing your own doubts. If no one else ever asks inconvenient questions, then you won't be tempted to do so either.

Cancer: Someone could seem to be invading your turf at the moment. After the perceptive Moon shifts into your social 11th house, asking your friends for their view of the situation may help. You shouldn't necessarily follow their advice blindly.

Leo: A current power struggle in a close relationship could be more complicated than it appears. While the vulnerable Moon in your visible 10th house goads underhanded Pluto in your partnership zone, the person who makes the biggest emotional display may not truly.

Virgo: Working hard can bring you rewarding results at this time. The only thing capable of holding you back could be your beliefs about your responsibilities. As the sensitive Moon in your philosophical 9th house clashes with driven Pluto in your 6th House of Work.

Libra: You're ready to advocate for your own pursuit of pleasure -- particularly if this desire has been suppressed for far too long. Now that it's roaring out in full force with passionate Mars and intense Pluto united in your self-absorbed 5th house.

Scorpio: Someone else's objections could frustrate your current plans to improve your living space. Perhaps you're having trouble hearing what their complaint is, because your mind goes directly to other times when you've had to defer.

Sagittarius: Coming on too strong in conversation is an ongoing risk. While the impulsive Moon in your 6th House of Responsibilities aggravates domineering Pluto in your communication sector.

Capricorn: Using money to throw your weight around could be tempting you. While motivated Mars and mastermind Pluto conspire in your 2nd House of Resources, you probably aspire to feel powerful and in control of a situation.

Aquarius: Making yourself look big and scary can help you feel safe at present. As assertive Mars and rooted Pluto meet in your sign, you're equipped to cast an intimidating presence.

Pisces: YTearing your perceived opposition down behind their backs could seem justified at the moment. As aggressive Mars meets vindictive Pluto in your subversive 12th house, the larger problem is probably.

CARTOON

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Host Nepal set for CWC League 2 face-off with Netherlands, Namibia

BY NAYAK PAUDEL
Kathmandu, Feb. 13



PHOTO FILE: CAN

Winning 11 of the final 12 matches in ICC CWC League 2's inaugural edition (2019-2023), Nepal secured a place in the 2023 World Cup qualifier tournament; however, the team could not advance to the World Cup hosted by India in 2023.

ICC CWC League 2, the second tier of international 50-over cricket, was introduced to induct the best associate teams into the World Cup after extending quotas. While there were seven teams in the first edition, the second edition of ICC CWC League 2 (2024-2027) has eight: Nepal, Namibia, Netherlands, Scotland, UAE, Oman, USA and Canada.

The eight teams will be competing in 24 tri-series of six matches each throughout the campaign. Nepal, Netherlands and Namibia are playing the first of the 24 tri-series at TU International Cricket Ground from February 15 to 25.

Assembling points of the eight teams from the 24 tri-series, the top four teams will advance to the 2027 World Cup Qualifiers.

Chris Tetley, ICC Head of Events, in a press statement released today on the first tri-series of League 2 starting in Nepal, said, "The League 2 fixtures are a very important part of our cricket calendar because… they provide a pathway to the ICC Men's Cricket World Cup 2027. The League 2 series provide Members with the opportunity to schedule T20I fixtures around their 50-over matches, providing an excellent opportunity to prepare for the World Cup in the T20 format (June 2024)."

Host on a roll

The year 2024 started well for Nepal's men's national cricket team as the team whitewashed a series on home soil for the first time. Playing with Canada in a bilateral series of 3 ODIs from February 8 to 12, Nepal won all three matches in style.

Furthermore, Nepal won the series with four young debutants – Surya Tamang, Aakash Chand, Hemant Dhami and Rijan Dhakal – and two inactive internationals – Anil Kumar Sah and Pawan Sarraf – returning for national duty. Meanwhile, three quality players – Dipendra Singh Airee, Karan KC and Gulshan Jha – were given rest during the friendly series.

Alongside winning most of the matches among associate members, the national team's performance at the Asia Cup and Asian Games against Pakistan and India in 2023 has boosted the players' morale as well. Expressing the team's mentality after winning the series against Canada, Nepal's captain Rohit Kumar Paudel said, "We are pleased to be hosting the first tri-series of League 2 as the campaign has several talented sides. We are more confident about our upcoming ICC League 2 matches after a 3-0 win over Canada. These are exciting times for us with the T20 World Cup less than four months away."

Starting with strong opponents

The Netherlands and Namibia are not weak teams. Moreover, the Dutch side is on a better roll than Nepal.

Qualifying for the World Cup in India last year, the Netherlands team secured two major victories against powerhouses South Africa and Bangladesh.

On the other hand, Namibia won a T20 series against Zimbabwe 3-2 in October 2023. Namibia defeated Zimbabwe once again in the ICC Men's T20 World Cup Africa Region Qualifiers in November 2023 and ended the qualifiers in the top position among seven teams unbeaten.

Both Namibia and the Netherlands have qualified for the T20 World Cup in June alongside Nepal. Moreover, the Dutch team is in the same group as Nepal, South Africa, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka for the World Cup.

The three teams will play two matches each in the tri-series. Nepal will face Namibia on February 15 and 21, and the Netherlands on February 17 and 25.

As per the 2024 calendar for League 2, after the first tri-series against Namibia and Netherlands, Nepal is scheduled to play against Canada and Oman in September, and Scotland and the USA in October.

All squads revealed

Squads of all three teams have now been revealed with Namibia revealing its squad for the League 2 matches on Monday evening.

Nepal's squad for League 2 was announced alongside the squad for the series against Canada. Rohit Kumar Paudel is captaining the squad comprising Aasif Sheikh, Kushal Bhurtel, Kushal Malla, Aarif Sheikh, Pawan Sarraf, Bhim Sharki, Arjun Saud, Dipendra Singh Airee, Gulshan Jha, Sompal Kami, Karan KC, Lali Rajbanshi, Surya Tamang and Rijan Dhakal. Pratish GC, Dev Khanal, Anil Kumar Sah and Bibek Yadav have been kept as reserves.

The Royal Dutch Cricket Federation, aka KNCB, made public its squad visiting Nepal on February 9. Scott Edwards is likely to captain the team of Max O'Dowd, Vikramjit Singh, Noah Croes, Shariz Ahmad, Aryan Dutt, Teja Nidamanuru, Michael Levitt, Vivian Kingma, Wesley Barresi, Sybrand Engelbrecht, Roelof van der Merwe, Bas de Leede, Kylie Klien and Olivier Elenbaas.

The Namibian side, which is currently known as 'Richelieu Eagles' after Richelieu announced a three-year sponsorship of Namibia's national cricket team in 2022, is being led by captain Gerhard Erasmus. Other players in the squad are Zane Green, JJ Smit, Michael van Lingen, Nicol Loftie-Eaton, Shaun Fouche, Ben Shikongo, Jan Frylinck, Ruben Trumpelmann, Niko Davin, Tangeni Lungameni, Jack Brassell, Bernard Scholtz, JP Kotze and Malan Kruger.

WIndies earn consolation win against Australia

AP
Perth, Feb. 13



Andre Russell and Sherfane Rutherford smashed half centuries in a record-breaking sixth-wicket stand to propel the West Indies to 37-run consolation win over Australia in the third and final Twenty20 match on Tuesday.

Russell destroyed the pace and spin of Adam Zampa late in the innings to score 71 off just 29 balls while Rutherford contributed 67 off 40 deliveries as West Indies posted 220-6 after winning the toss and electing to bat.

David Warner briefly kept Australia in the hunt for a 3-0 sweep in the series with 81 off 49 balls before the home team faltered against offspinner Roston Chase and was restricted to 183-5.

Chase, one of the two changes West Indies made for the final game, derailed Australia's pursuit with the wickets of Warner and Josh Inglis in one over to end up with 2-19.

"It's a very good feeling to come here and get a win," West Indies captain Rowman Powell said after losing the series 2-1. "The boys showed some heart and courage. We had good plans through the three games but execution let us down."

Australia fast bowler Xavier Bartlett, who impressed in his ODI debut against the West Indies, continued to prosper in white-ball cricket by getting openers Johnson Charles and Kyle Mayers in his debut T20 after Josh Hazlewood was rested for the final game.

Charles edged Barlett's fifth delivery to wicket-keeper Inglis and Mayers played a short ball back onto his stumps in the pacer's second over. Zampa had Chase (37) clean bowled soon after the batting powerplay and when Powell edged Aaron Hardie behind the wickets the West Indies stuttered at 79-5 in the ninth over.

But Russell and Rutherford didn't get bogged down against the pace and revived things with a strong partnership. They raised the best-ever sixth-wicket stand in a T20 international by contributing an aggressive 139 runs off just 67 balls. Zampa's penultimate over went for 28 with Russell clubbing four sixes and a four and the legspinner finished with 1-65 – the most expensive figures by an Australia in a T20.

Russell, who hit seven sixes and four boundaries, finally holed out at mid-off in the last over of fast bowler Spencer Johnson (1-49).

SNIPPETS

Gyanendra, Shakti now ICC Level 2 coach

Kathmandu (TRN): Former national cricket players Shakti Gauchan and Gyanendra Malla with Gandaki Province Cricket head coach Rijan Praju have completed the ICC Level 2 coaching course in Singapore. Former Bangladeshi and Pakistani cricketers Aminul Islam and Iqbal Sikander were the trainers in the course. Alongside the trio from Nepal, there were 24 individuals in the coaching course from several other Asian countries. The CAN informed that Gyanendra secured the top rank in the final result of the coaching course followed by Shakti and Rijan. Gyanendra has started his coaching journey with APF Club from the PM Men's Cup 2024.

Chelsea wins at Palace

London (AFP): Conor Gallagher struck twice to condemn his former club Crystal Palace to a damaging 3-1 defeat on Monday and keep Chelsea in the hunt for European football next season. The injury-ravaged Eagles were on course for a huge win in their battle to remain in the Premier League when Jefferson Lerma's long-range strike opened the scoring. But Palace have won just three times in 19 games and were undone late on after Gallagher equalised within two minutes of the second half. Gallagher fired home his second of the night and Enzo Fernandez added the third in stoppage time to lift Chelsea up to 10th and within two points of seventh. Defeat leaves Palace still just five points above the relegation zone in 15th.

Udinese hands Inter title gift

Turin (AFP): Inter Milan have a seven-point lead and a game in hand at the top of Serie A after their closest challengers Juventus fell to a shock 1-0 home defeat to Udinese on Monday. Juve's title hopes took a hit at the Allianz Stadium in Turin after Lautaro Giannetti poked home the only goal of the game in the 25th minute. Argentine defender Giannetti's strike was his first since signing for Udinese last month and gave his team just their third league win of the season. Gabriele Cioffi's Udinese are three points above the relegation zone after consigning disappointing Juve to their second straight defeat after last weekend's narrow loss at Inter. Juve meanwhile are now looking over their shoulders as AC Milan are just a point behind them in third thanks to a 1-0 win over Napoli on Sunday night.

'Hard graft' from all-rounders leads South Africa fightback

AFP
Hamilton, Feb. 13



PHOTO: AFP

New Zealand's Rachin Ravindra (R) bowls on day one of the second Test cricket match against South Africa at Seddon Park in Hamilton on Tuesday.

All-rounders Ruan de Swardt and Shaun von Berg used "hard graft" to lead a South African rearguard on Tuesday as they reached 220-6 after New Zealand had dominated the start of the second Test.

De Swardt reached his maiden half-century and was 55 not out at stumps on day one. The 37-year-old Von Berg was 34 on his Test debut, with the pair having put on an unbroken 70 off 27 overs at Seddon Park in Hamilton.

South Africa won the toss but were 64-3 at lunch and tottering at 150-6 early in the final session after David Bedingham was dismissed in freakish fashion.

After losing in Mount Maunganui by 281 runs, an understrength South Africa must win to avoid becoming the first team from their country to lose a Test series to New Zealand.

De Swardt, who had been one of six Proteas debutants in the first Test, showed the specialist batsmen how to survive in a gritty 135-ball knock.

He received support from veteran leg-spinner von Berg, who was finally given an international opportunity after playing 135 first-class matches.

"It was quite hard graft out there," de Swardt said.

"I thought the New Zealanders bowled pretty well but for me it was just about getting stuck into them, having that mental toughness and keeping going.

"There's still quite a bit in the wicket so if we can bat well tomorrow, get past 300, 350, we're definitely in with a chance."

The pair halted a mini-collapse either side of the tea break inspired by Rachin Ravindra, who took 3-33.

Ravindra, who scored 240 in the first Test, underlined his all-round talent by removing Zubayr Hamza for a painstaking 20 off 99 balls and Keegan Petersen for two. His left-arm spin then accounted for the unfortunate Bedingham, on 39, whose leg-side flick struck the top of his shoe and flew to close-in fielder Will Young.

South Africa made a dreadful start when makeshift opener Clyde Fortuin was dismissed for nought first ball in the second over, caught brilliantly in the gully by Glenn Phillips off Matt Henry.

Pace bowler Will O'Rourke took a wicket on debut when he had captain Neil Brand trapped leg before for 25 midway through the first session.

Raynard van Tonder was then out for 32 just before lunch, caught at gully after failing to get on top of Neil Wagner's short delivery.

ANCELOTTI NOT WORRIED ABOUT BELLINGHAM'S ABSENCE IN CL

AP
Leipzig, Feb. 13

Carlo Ancelotti thinks Real Madrid has already proven it can cope without the injured Jude Bellingham, who is set to miss Tuesday's Champions League match against Leipzig in the round of 16.

Madrid will play the first-leg match in Germany with a depleted midfield because of the absence of the injured England international, who sprained his left ankle in a Spanish league match this past weekend.

Madrid had not given a timetable for Bellingham's return but Ancelotti confirmed Monday he will miss the game. "We have won all four matches that we played without Bellingham," Ancelotti said. "He is an important player, but it's an opportunity for the others to be motivated."

Brahim Díaz is expected to play in Bellingham's place, alongside Toni Kroos, Federico Valverde and Eduardo Camavinga in the midfield. Vinícius Júnior and Rodrygo are set to play in attack.

"Despite the absence of Bellingham, they have a strong attack, and we cannot focus on just one player," Leipzig goalkeeper Peter Gulacsi said. "We know about Madrid's individual quality. Vinícius Júnior played a fantastic game at the weekend, there is also Rodrygo, we can name everyone. In the center of the field, they have a lot of quality."

Bellingham scored twice in Madrid's 4-0 win against Girona to take his season tally to 20 goals, but left the game at halftime because of the ankle injury.

Ancelotti remains without some of its central defenders as well because of injury, including David Alaba, Éder Militão and Antonio Rüdiger. Midfielder Aurélien Tchouaméni is likely to be deployed in the middle of the defense along with Nacho Fernández. Another option would be to play right back Dani Carvajal in the position.

Spanish media said the team's bus was involved in a minor traffic accident in Germany on Monday. It said Madrid had to travel to Leipzig by bus from another German city because of a strike at the Leipzig airport.

WEATHER

Wednesday

Sunrise at 6:43 am, Sunset at 5:53 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Wednesday)

Partly to generally cloudy throughout the country.. Light rain is likely to occur at one or two places of hilly regions of the country. Chances of light snowfall at a few places of the high hilly and mountainous region of the country.

Expected Temp.: 22-24 Rain Probability: 0%

Tuesday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dipayal	25.2	4.1	0.0
Dadeldhura	18.0	4.4	0.0
Dhangadi	26.4	8.5	0.0
Birendranagar	25.3	6.9	0.0
Nepalgunj	27.3	9.8	0.0
Jumla	17.5	-4.9	0.0
Ghorahi	24.7	8.5	0.0
Pokhara	23.5	8.3	0.0
Bhairahawa	26.5	7.7	0.0
Simara	26.7	8.5	0.0
Kathmandu	22.4	5.2	0.0
Okhaldhunga	20.6	8.2	0.0
Taplejung	18.7	5.5	0.0
Dhankuta	24.2	8.5	0.0
Biratnagar	27.8	6.9	0.0
Jomsom	12.1	-2.0	0.0*
Dharan	28.0	12.3	0.0*
Lumle	18.5	6.0	0.0*
Janakpur	28.4	8.0	0.0*
Jiri	16.4	-0.8	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

February 14, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.51	Rs. 133.11
Euro	1	Rs. 142.86	Rs. 143.51
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 167.94	Rs. 168.70
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 150.67	Rs. 151.36
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 86.45	Rs. 86.84
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.56	Rs. 99.01
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.54	Rs.98.99
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.87	Rs. 8.91
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.42	Rs. 18.50
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.33	Rs. 35.49
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.34	Rs. 36.50
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.71	Rs. 3.73
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.08	Rs. 36.24
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 27.80	Rs. 27.93
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.97	Rs. 10.01
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.71	Rs. 12.77
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.16	Rs. 19.25
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.95	Rs. 17.03
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.33	Rs. 432.27
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.52	Rs. 353.11

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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